**PREFACE to Richard Cansdale's story with the working title of**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT.**

**It was a chance encounter on a train to London that first made me think seriously about writing up some of my life's experiences. I was sitting opposite an American Lady who was on the staff of a magazine and we started talking.**

**'Do you live in London?' she asked me.**

**'No, I live in a beautiful part of Northumberland, but I lived in London until I was twenty.'**

**'Oh, whereabouts did you live?'**

**How I replied to that question depended on whether I wanted to go on chatting. I could have just said 'In North London', but instead I said that from the age of one to six we lived in Regent's Park before moving to NW2.**

**'Whereabouts in Regent's Park' she asked. I then explained how when I was just a year old my father returned from Africa to take up a post with grand sounding title of Superintendant of London Zoo, and that our house was actually in the middle of the zoo itself.**

**She was incredulous but started asking me how much I could remember about my life in the zoo. 'Well to be honest, I can remember a lot, as if it was just yesterday in fact.' It was then as we talked she started saying what a wonderful story it could make. Curiously it was a few years before the rather bizarre story The life of Pi was published, but I did admit it was the most wonderful environment for a small child to grow up in. I can trace my interest in animals and the natural environment to those early years and didn't even mind the taunts of my school friends about living in the monkey house. I put them down to jealousy.**

**David, my brother is two years older than me, so after he started school I was on my own at home. I'm pretty sure if my mother was to have done today what she did then she would have been in big trouble with Social Services, but she was happy for me to roam the zoo by myself on my tricycle during the mornings, with a note pinned to my back saying "PLEASE SEND ME HOME AT 12'o Clock for LUNCH"**

**I came to no harm, or at least not very often. My trike had no brakes, and if you have ever been to London Zoo you may remember how it is divided in two by a road (The Outer Circle). Two tunnels allow the public to access both side of the zoo, so for me it was great sport to come round the corner, then with legs off the pedals and wide apart, whizz down the tunnel at top speed. That was all very well until one day I came round the corner to see the tunnel was full of people. I aimed for a small gap to the left - see, I remember it well - but hit the concrete wall instead. Luckily the zoo's electric meat wagon came upon me, scraped me up and to the first aid post.**

**Apparently apart from a bent nose, which I have to this day I was relatively unscathed.**

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**Well, dear friends, that is my two penny worth for starters. If the bug gets me that might be all you'll ever get, and I will forgive you for thinking 'thank goodness for that' but much as I love Bonny her conversation is somewhat limited, so this project might keep me relatively sane.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT.**

**Page 2.**

**Life in the Zoo.**

**Our house in the zoo, long since demolished, was between Regents Park's Outer Circle and the Regent's Canal. From my bedroom window I looked down on the canal, which was still in commercial use, and can clearly remember horse drawn barges. Beyond the canal was Primrose Hill and to the left a white block of flats which are still there in Ormonde Terrace. - you can see them by using Street View on Google Maps! I mention this because I named the flats The Teddies' Gonking School. Now why might a small child come up with that name? For a long time I could think of no logical answer, but then I realised that when lying in bed I could often hear a dull thumping sound. It was my heart beating, but my explanation was more imaginative. I could hear the teddies Gonking.**

**Lying in bed, in addition to the continuous gonking of the Teds, I could hear other sounds. The Kookaburras were within earshot, and their call was the first bird sound I knew. Also known as the Laughing Jackass, not a bad name for some people I know today, their distinctive cackle was loud and clear. I could also hear the lions roaring at night. They didn't worry me as much as the leopard I was convinced lived under my bed. I had to turn out the light and leap onto the bed to stop it getting me.**

**I must have known the grounds better than most visitors, and on at least one occasion I was 'found' by a well meaning member of the public who took me to the lost property office. I must have played along with this, but that got me into trouble with father and I don't think I did it again knowingly.**

**My favourite animals were Dixie, the female African Elephant, Prince, a beautiful Cheetah, and Rajah a very tame tiger, who father would stroke through the bars. This did cause serious trouble when day David and I climbed over the safety rail to get closer to Rajah. Too close! I don't think we touched him, but we had been seen by the head keeper. Later that day we were heading off for a family picnic, when as luck would have it just as we were driving past the offices as the wretched man was crossing the road. He flagged my father down and snitched on us. Perhaps he also saved our lives, but there was no picnic that day.**

**Rats were a menace and a sixpence bounty was paid for any caught. Father had a shotgun and some evenings we accompanied him on his rounds. He would shoot rats in the moats in front of the Mappin Terraces. I had a swing in the garden and one day I washed it with a rag and a bucket of water. I didn't put the bucket away, but in the night a rat climbed into the bucket and drowned. Poor rat, but I was rich with my sixpence.**

**World War II had only finished three years before we moved to the zoo. Rationing was still in force and times were hard, so people had to make do as best they could. Unfortunately not everyone was honest, and among the zoo staff there were opportunists who used their situations to their advantage.**

**As the public paid to come into the Zoo they moved through turnstiles which recorded the numbers entering. It was cash only and this temptation was too much for some. At some point father realised that the numbers coming into the zoo did not tally with the takings at the gates so he decided to investigate. He soon learned that the turnstiles were far from foolproof, and offered several ways to be tricked. I think he said in addition to one or two obvious techniques there were another half a dozen more subtle ways to cheat. It was when father saw the man in charge of the gates coming to work by taxi, a luxury out of the reach of his salary, that he had to act. Father would of course have known exactly how much he was earning so he had the turnstiles removed and replaced by new Automaticket machines. (You could buy a vintage one today on eBay for £200.)**

**There were other 'rackets', as father called them, rife in the zoo. A lot of food intended for the animals ended up on dinner plates, but one ingenious scheme only came to light when he inspected the reptile house late on night. As he went in he saw what he described as rafts of cockroaches on the floor. Thousands of them! When he demanded action be taken to, suggesting poison, the objections by the keepers was extreme. It turned out the cockroaches were being bred intentionally and sold to schools and colleges for dissection in the biology lessons.**

**Stamping out these practices did not go down well with staff. They did not forget what he had done, so when father's post was abolished a few years later, despite a massive public outcry, they had their revenge. More of this story in another chapter.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. page 3**

**My first two posts were my childhood memories until I was six, but at this point I will answer a question often asked "How did your father come to be given the post of running London Zoo."**

**The explanation I will give you could fill a book of its own. It is fascinating, but here is the short version.**

**My parents, George and Sheila met at Oxford University in the very early 1930's but they were from entirely different backgrounds. My father's father was a clerk for a shipping company in the London docks, my mother's grandfather had founded a large department store in Southsea, Handley's. At its peak the store employed 500 staff, and something I found out only recently, when there as a local airshow a company making kit planes approached Handley's offering them an agency for their planes. My great grandfather must have a sense of humour, because in flyer (excuse the pun) for the store's general products it included these words. "Also Airplanes, care of the Plumbing Department".**

**So, going back to my parents, they had met at University. My father studied Forestry, my mother History. My father graduated in 1932 but it was during depths of the depression. (Sounds familiar?) Most of the forestry graduates would have expected to get jobs with the Colonial Service in either Africa, or Asia, but in 1932 there were NO jobs on offer. None. Father did a one year research degree studying the Classification of the Black Poplars, really exciting stuff, but it gained him an FLS (Fellow of the Linnean Sociiety). The following year there were four posts advertised by the Colonial Service for forestry, but by then there were graduates from two years from four universities after them. In addition to Oxford, Edingburgh, London and Bangor offered degrees in forestry.**

**Father had spent at least one summer in Germany and had learned German, and he believes it was this which clinched the job for him.**

**So in 1934 a 25 year old George Cansdale headed off for West Africa, destination the Gold Coast, now Ghana.**

**For a young man whose interest was natural history, to be spending his working life in the tropical rain forest was heaven. Unlike East Africa, with its large game parks, the West African wildlife was much less known, so father was in his element studying and collecting animals. His particular interests became small mammals and reptiles.**

**For years his day job was conducting surveys of the forest, identifying the types, quantities and maturity of the different commercial tree species, This involved trecking out into the forest for about three weeks at a time, but this gave him an excellent opportunity to collect animals. Soon after arriving he had got to grips with the local language 'Twi'. (The T pronounced 'ch', so "Chwee".) He remained fluent for the rest of his life and on several occasion in London when he spotted someone who he could tell was Ghanaian he would ask they where they came from. If, as he correctly suspected, they where native Twi speakers, he would reduce them to either hysterics or tears when the started speaking together in Twi. Once he was on a bus sitting behind two ladies speaking Twi. As he got up to leave he leant forwards and said quietly "Be careful what you say, you never know who might be listening."**

**I must tell you about a funny incident I once had. A few years ago I was in London with Sue attending a Transplant conference at Church House in Westminster. Afterwards we took the opportunity to visit the House of Parliament. It was mid December.**

**I guessed that the lift attendant was West African. He confirmed that he was indeed. Ghanaian. I only know two or three Twi expressions, 'Mi num' which means 'i drink', and 'Mi num' which means 'I don't drink'. Hold on, aren't they the same words? Exactly! It is a tonal language, so the slightest difference in tone is needed to distinguish them.**

**My third expression is 'Afrishiapa madam foo' which as it happens means 'Happy Christmat my friend.' The lovely lift attendant was gob smacked when I wished him Happy Christmas in his own language, but disappointed that was virtually all the Twi I knew, but then was amused when I told him I was 'made in Ghana'. "So you are an African!" he told me.**

**I'm afraid this chapter is going to be quite long, especially if i am going to digress, so i am taking a break now.**

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**Today looks like serious lock down. Hang on in there lovely people. Phone someone you've not been in touch with over your morning coffee.**

**To be continued.....**

**Preface to THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. page 3 part 2.**

**Good morning all. Nationally we are now in virtual lock-down. We are facing a crisis at so many levels, nationally certainly. For most of us in the UK we are facing a personal crisis too. Everything we took for granted has been pulled from under us. We are facing a time a uncertainty the likes of which most of us under 75 have never experienced.**

**The story I have started to tell in these pages will include incidents in my life which ranged from the hilarious to the tragic. Like many of us, I have experienced the highs and lows of human existence. I am sure in the future we will be asked how we coped.**

**This morning I will be talking about my father's time in West Africa. He left England in 1934 having fallen in love with my mother. It was the time of great depression. A time of massive uncertainty. He was setting off for an area known as 'The White Man's Grave', leaving the love of his life behind. Before long Europe would be in turmoil and another World War would be on the horizon. Yet he coped. My own father overcame all those challenges. I find that so very inspiring, so today I hope his story will encourage all of us to ask ourselves how we can make the best of this wretched situation and come out stronger at the other end.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. page 3 part 2.**

**In the 1930's the Gold Coast, now Ghana, was a British colony. I am conscious of fact that the history of Europe's colonial past is extremely controversial and was not all good. But it was not all bad either, and many times my father told me how he saw his role as helping to set up a sustainable forestry industry which would stand the county in good stead when it became independent.**

**That is all I will say about that subject. My story is about the personal experience of one very junior forester, just 25 years old, starting a new career in a foreign country, where many of known for the diseases, could kill you, with constant high temperatures and high humidity. Sounds really inviting, doesn't it.**

**The question was, what had attracted my father to a career in forestry? The answer was simple. He loved wildlife and natural history. He had grown up in Essex and from an early age learned all the bird songs. He fished, and one one occasion saved a young otter from irate fishermen intent on killing it, so I am certain he was looking forward to studying the local wildlife.**

**His forest survey work presented a golden opportunity for this and the technique he developed was pure genius. When setting off for a survey, often for tree weeks at a time and on foot with a team of local bearers carrying all the equipment, the route would take him through a series of villages. As he reached a village he would say to the chief, "Please tell your hunters, farmers and small boys, (and I'm sure small girls too), that I will be coming back in about two weeks, and will pay for any animals they find. I will pay more than they would receive if they sold them for chop (food), and I will pay more for them if they are alive, and not dead."**

**This was a perfect plan and soon his reputation started to grow. Back at his house he was building up a collection of animals, bur which I mean small mammals and reptiles. I don't know how or when his interest in snakes began, but in time he became the leading expert in West African snakes.**

**This might interest you. Go into Ebay now and in the search bar type just one word... 'Cansdale'. Tick 'All categories' an tick the little box which says 'Include Description'. See how many animal books pop up, and note the author.**

**Anyway, back to George's story. As his reputation for his interest in animals grew, so more people would seek him out and bring him specimens, and so his collection grew. Long before the wars in the former Yugoslavia broke out he told me how he had a nick-name for a particular species of ground squirrel.**

**Unlike most of the other animals who coexisted quite happily with their own kind, these squirrels constantly fought. He called them 'The Balkans' As a child I had no idea what this meant, but how true that was!**

**Before I take a break, let me tell you one of my favourite stories. Before I do I must explain a bit about Pidgin English. In areas where there are many different languages, one language tends to become the main trading language spoken as a second language by people whose mother tongues were the minor languages. So for example, in East Africa Swahili is the main trading language, whilst in northern Nigeria, Niger and Chad, Hausa is the equivalent Elsewhere in north Africa it is Arabic.**

**In West Africa Pidgin English is still the common dialect in Ghana, Sierra Leone, Liberia and southern Nigeria. Nowadays many only speak Pidgin, but those with a good education speak perfect English, but equally can speak Pidgin too. It is a wonderful variety of English with its own grammar and use of words. From my childhood I had heard my father tell wonderful stories in Pidgin, so by time I first went to Africa I was already quite familiar with it and soon picked it up.**

**So this gives me an opportunity to tell you the first Pidgin English story.**

**My father just returned from an exhausting trek. He was tired, hungry and dirty and all he wanted to do was have a bath and go to bed, but his steward called out to him.**

**"Massa, der be man here for door. He has fowl. Make you come lookum."**

**(Posh translation. 'Sir, there is a gentleman at the front door. He is holding a bird/chicken. Would you be kind enough to come and see it?) Editor's note. I prefer the Pidgin version.**

**Father. 'Sorry, I'm very tired. I going to have a bath, please thank him but say not today'.**

**Steward. 'Massa, dees fowl be beeg fowl. Make you come lookum. ( I think you are getting hang of it now.)**

**Father. Sorry, I don't mind how big it is. Please say not today!'**

**Steward. 'But Massa, dees fowl he be beeg pass all fowl.Make you come lookum!'**

**At this point my father had not alternative but to go and investigate. There at door was a man holding a piece of string, attached to which, if you haven't guessed, was an OSTRICH.**

**TO BE CONTINUED.....**

**Enjoy your day dear friends. Phone a friend. Support someone who is feeling low, or think about writing up your story for your grand kids.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. page 3 part 3.**

**Just a quick note before I start writing today. As from today I will also post these ramblngs on the 'Your Story' page. Please don't feel you need to read all, or even any of these stories. I am pleased that a few of you are finding them interesting, but at the end of the exercise they might, just might, be pulled together into a single ebook. All you are getting for now are my thoughts as they spill onto the page, bypassing the brain.**

**I hope you too are finding ways to cope with the Self Isolating message. This is helping me. So here goes,**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. page 3 part 3.**

**George threw himself into his forestry work and soon learned the local language, Twi He would proudly tell me that he was the first European to learn it to translator standard. This greatly assisted his ability to learn about the wildlife in the forests from the local people.**

**Over next few years built up a collection of live animals, recorded as many mammals and reptiles as he could and even discovered half a dozen new species or sub species as yet not known to science. These included Mrs. Cansdale's Bat, and the unromantic sounding Cansdale's Swamp Rat.**

**Some 40 years after leaving Ghana George was speaking to a Rotary club in York when after the talk a Rotarian came up to him and said 'Mr. Cansdale, when I worked in Ghana I lived in the house you had lived in.' When father asked how he knew that he was surprised by the answer.**

**'When I was allocated the house several people told me how lucky I was to have it. I asked why and was told 'Many years ago a man lived in that house who had power over the snakes. His spirit is still there so thieves will not go there. " '**

**He had taken up his post in 1934, and every two years was able to come home on leave. My parents had met at Oxford University but did not get married until September 1940. They were married in All Souls, Langham Place on Saturday the 7th September. I mention this for two reasons. First, you have often seen pictures of this church, possibly without knowing its name. It is the church alongside BBC Broadcasting House with the ring of columns, and tall conical spire. It is often shown before or during news programmes. It was designed by the architect Nash, along with many of the building in Regents Park. The church was to play a big part in my parents' lives for many years.**

**The second reason I mention the date of the wedding was that 7th September 1940 was the first day of the daylight blitz. As my parents traveled to Devon on the train for their honeymoon they remarked on the sunset, until they realised they were looking EAST ..... at London burning!**

**After the wedding my father returned alone to Africa. He was never in the armed services other than the equivalent of the Home Guard. His knowledge of German meant that he had to check the letters of German Internees for compromising information. The only thing of interest he found was a blank note book along with covering letter saying that in view of the shortage of paper at home, here is something for you. His suspicions were aroused and he discovered the pages had been written with invisible ink, giving details of shipping in Takoradi harbour.**

**He was in charge of one two platoons. During on exercise his platoon was to attack Government House, the other platoon had to defend it. Did he commandeer an Ambulance, Dirty Dozen style? No, he used the dust cart. Having washed it out first, he piled his platoon into the back and drove in through the gates unchallenged.**

**During the war father's role was supervising workshops making furniture for the forces. Tables and chairs and beds. He had a reputation for spotting disguised defects so he carried with him a hammer with which he could reveal shoddy repairs with a well aimed tap. As he approached the cry would go up "The lion is coming.The lion is coming." At the end of the war he was presented with a magnificent traditional wooden stool fashioned as a lion.**

**My mother visited my father for two tours, first in 1943/4, and then in 1945/6.**

**Visiting Africa for the first time can be quite a culture shock, but one of the things my mother was not expecting was to hear my father speaking Pidgin English to his staff.**

**"I don't mind you speaking in this funny way to your staff, but I hope you won't expect me to" she said to him. My father told her not to worry, but a few days late his steward approached him looking very concerned.**

**"What's the problem?" he asked, The reply was classic, especially considering my mother's education and upbringing.**

**"Massa, dis missus, why she no speak proper? I no fit hear-um!"**

**The end of the war.**

**My paternal grandmother, was from a Paignton family in Devon and father had links with the Zoo. Along with most European Zoos their animal collections had suffered during the war years so father arranged a shipment of animals to Paignton Zoo. He also had contacts with London Zoo and I understand he also sent a significant number of animals to them too. I don't know how many consignment he send to London, but they included monkeys, snakes and other animals of interest, but clearly he impressed them with both his knowledge of the animals he sent and the efficiency with which he sent them, so when they were looking for someone to take up the post of Superintendent, responsible for the running of the Zoo itself, they offered him the job.**

**He therefore resigned from the Colonial Service and in 1948 started his new job, and new career at London Zoo. I was just one year old.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. page 3 part 4**

**Before I pick up, a short comment on our present crisis.**

**Good morning dear friends. I wonder how many of you keep diaries? I would not consider myself to be particularly disciplined, but from the time I was about ten years old I started keeping diaries. To start with they were just single years, and the entries were pretty basic, but over the years I started to write up a bit more.**

**I now keep FIVE YEAR diaries. I started a new one this year, but the first year is a bit dull. By the fifth year you can look back over the previous four years and be reminded of events you might otherwise have forgotten all about. It is a silly habit, but quite fun. The period we are now experiencing is the most challenging most of us will ever have experienced.**

**As most of you will know Sue and I lost our most wonderful daughter Zoe in 1998 when she was 22. This year will be 22 years since she died. And for me it is now two years since Sue died. We often said Zoe would never have wished her loss to have destroyed our lives; likewise I know Sue felt the same.**

**I am so thankful that Sue did not have the additional worry of a pandemic for last few months of her life. She had so many friends visit her during her last few weeks, and the last she did before she fell asleep for the last time was to give an old school friend a massive smile.**

**I say this because we must be strong. We will all be tested, but for any of us who keep diaries, (and why not start one today if you don't already?) when next year we read what we have written today, we will think back and think "was it really like that?"**

**WELL ENOUGH RAMBLINGS, this leads me on nicely to conclude my father's time in Africa.**

**A few years ago I found my mother's five year diary covering the years 1942 to 1947. I didn't know she had one, although it is about somewhere I can't put my finger on it right now, but one thing interested me. Where were my parents nine months before I was born? So I looked up 13th June 1946.**

**It was clear they were in the Gold Coast, so I WAS made in Ghana, but better still, this is what she wrote. "KING'S BIRTHDAY. HOLIDAY!"**

**My father not only enjoyed his time in Africa but he made such full use of it it puts me to shame. Long before colour photography he took black and white photos of his animals and the life of the people. He processed most of the photos himself and would tell me how difficult this was because of the constant high humidity. Some of his pictures are archived with the Geographical Society's collections.**

**The Governor at the time, Sir Alan Burns, was also very interested in wildlife and they became friends. This friendship, between a lowly forestry officer and the senior civil servant, and the head of the Colonial Service in the country was resented by my father's bosses, and sometimes ruffled feathers, and might have been the reason he liked the expression "Those that matter don't mind. Those that mind don't matter."**

**In the following years I would learn how much he was respected by his African colleagues just as I know how much he respected them. It was strange for me, because although I was 22 before I went to Africa for the first time, and then had a total of 44 trips between 1969 and 2010, it almost felt like going home. My father's experiences had rubbed off on me as a child and stood me in good stead when I started working in African water development years later.**

**In the previous chapter I mentioned how my father sent many animals back to England after the war. Thanks to a very timely reminder from my cousin Michael Cansdale, who was very close to my father and went to the same college as him, I can tell you how he was able to do that.**

**This is Michael writing.....**

**"My uncle George Cansdale, was at St Edmund Hall, Oxford, from 1929 to 1934. In 1934 he joined the Colonial Service and was immediately sent out, at the age of 24, to be a Forestry Officer in the Gold Coast (now Ghana). He stayed there throughout the war when his role was to send timber back to Britain and to the colonies for the war effort.**

**But, what was he to do with the extensive collection that he was building up? He got in touch with his old University friend, Francis Finch, who was overseas freight manager for Imperial Airways and then later BOAC. Whenever a plane landed at Accra with spare cargo space, Finch would arrange, pro bono, that animals and reptiles (snakes in particular, and small animals like bushbabies) could be loaded on board, and sent back to the London Zoo and other European zoos, whose stock had been depleted during the war. (If only informal arrangements with airlines could be made so easily nowadays by friendship with their senior staff!)**

**The direct result was that when in 1947 the Council of The London Zoological Society needed to appoint a new Superintendent to run the Zoo, they head-hunted Cansdale, who they knew to be not only a knowledgable naturalist but also a great supporter of and contributor to their collection.**

**As a boy I regularly stayed with him at the Superintendent's House in the Zoo grounds in Regent's Park.**

**Very quickly after his appointment at the Zoo he realised the potential publicity that could be obtained for the Zoo by using radio and the new medium of television to show interesting animals, live, in the studio. He became one of the best known presenters of wildlife programmes and items on British TV between the 1950s and the 1980s, and made regular appearances on Children's Hour, and, for many years, on Blue Peter. David Attenborough, who joined the BBC as a junior manager in 1952, and quickly became involved in programmes from the London Zoo, has paid warm tribute to George Cansdale's pioneering work in that field."**

**Dear friends,**

**before I continue with .....**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT, PAGE 4 part 2.**

**THE DUKE OF BEDFORD AND SOME FISHY TALES**

**I would just like to share some thoughts with you this Sunday morning.**

**The Corona virus news is getting grimmer every day, and is likely continue getting worse for a while yet. A sister of one of my friends died of it last week, a close friend is recovering from it and a son of other close friends has just contracted it.**

**Times are going to be very very hard in lots of ways.**

**We can all look back over our lives and remember the grimmest times we have gone through. 22 years ago we lost our most wonderful, vibrant daughter, very suddenly. It was too dreadful for words, yet life went on, and some positive things even came out of it.**

**Bad times are nothing new in the history of mankind. I fear as a civilisation we thought we were somehow immune. We are not, and we are not as clever as we perhaps like to think we are.**

**In 1969 I spent several months on Lake Chad. This story will feature later in my ramblings. My only companion was my 'boss', a woman twice my age who on top of serious 'gender identification' issues was also suffering from PTSD. I was the constant target of her wrath. It was the most horrible experience imaginable.**

**During that period I came across a text which helped me immeasurably, and helped me to survive. The verse was from the New Testament, (Hebrews 12, v.11) It says.....**

**"Now no chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous: nevertheless afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness unto them which are exercised thereby."**

**That is the King James version. A more modern translation says....**

**"We don't enjoy being disciplined. It always seems to cause more pain than joy. But later on, those who learn from that discipline have peace that comes from doing what is right."**

**For my twopenny worth I would like to offer my own translation.**

**"Times like this are absolute hell. But if we can endure them , and do what we have to do, when we emerge at the other side we will have learned from them and be stronger as a result."**

**All I will add is that although those few months on Lake Chad was very grim time for me, ultimately the experience had a massive positive influence on my life.**

**Sorry. I am meant to be getting on with my narrative, but I just wanted to share those thoughts with you. I hope they offered you a little encouragement .**

**Love to you all.**

**Richard.**

**Back to the writing..... TTFN**

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. page 4

Mr. Ezra and Mandarins.

So the story so far describes how George was able to use his time as a forest officer in the Gold Coast (Ghana) to collect and study the local animals, and then after the Second World War how was helped by a friend send to send a lot the animals back to England to restock, London and Paignton Zoos.

This led to an invitation to become Superintendent of the London Zoo in Regents Park.

For my older brother David and myself growing up in the zoo was amazing. It was our home because our house was in the middle of the zoo. Our immediate neighbours were the hippos, then the giraffes beyond them.

Father was only 38 when he took up his post, and having just returned from fourteen years in Africa he had few close friends near by, but he was befriended by a number of people who shared his interests.

Children are very accepting of the world around them, so to accompany our parents to lunch invitations was part of the territory. We didn't ask questions; we just went. One regular invitation was to have lunch with a certain 'Mr. Ezra', an elderly man who lived in Surrey. He was involved with the Zoo, and had a house near Cobham. A mansion might be a more accurate description.

The lunches were formal with a capital F. The massive table was set out with the finest silver and glassware. There were finger bowls and I lost count of the number of courses, served of course by the staff.

Mr. Ezra had a large estate, and after lunch we would walk in the grounds, except I would ride in Mr. Ezra's invalid chair, crouching down at his feet. It was one of those old fashioned elongated chairs with large wheels at the back and a single one out in front, and electrified. There we free living wallabies in the grounds, numerous nest boxes my father checked for occupancy, but apart from that I knew very little else about Mr. Ezra.

Roll on sixty years and one day I am walking beside the burn when I am astonished to see the gaudiest of all the ducks. A drake Mandarin Duck. (I will attach a picture of one, not one I took myself, so you can see what I mean.)

Mandarin Ducks are Chinese and favoured by wild fowl collectors for their ponds. I suppose the Mandarin is the equivalent of Koi Carp. But what was a Mandarin Duck doing in Hartburn? Funnily enough I had always thought of Mandarin Ducks a being so over the top that they looked unnatural. Even artificial; but when I saw it in its natural environment I saw how wonderful it looks.

I continued to see a single Mandarin drake for a few years, then a pair, and then a small flock of them. In 2018 I saw sixteen together a couple of times, and last year my friend and neighbour Gary saw the mum with about a dozen ducklings. This spring I have see a pair several times, but yesterday I saw just the drake four times. My guess is the female is nesting somewhere. (Factoids. They nest in holes in trees. They nest late so often suffer from a housing shortage so their populations only grow slowly, and are about the only non-native species in the country which causes no environmental damage.)

I have now learned that there is a strong population of Mandarin ducks in the Kielder/Tarset area, One day, returning from a day out at Kielder Dam I pulled over to allow some cars to pass where the road is close to the North Tyne. As I glanced to my left I was astonished to see about 25 Mandarin Ducks sitting around on exposed rocks on the river banks.

By now my curiosity was firmly aroused. Where did all these Mandarin Ducks come from?

Five minutes Googling and I had the answer. "Mandarin Ducks were first kept in this country by the eminent bird collector Albert Ezra on his estate in Surrey, and the feral population originated from there."

As with so much Googling, you can't leave it there, so I then started probing deeper. Who was Mr. Ezra? Well it's all out there for you to discover but I'll tell you what I found. Albert Ezra was born in 1872 in India. His mother and wife were members of the Sassoon Family. Yes, they included Siegfried Sassoon. The Sassoon family were very successful bankers in China and were known as the Rothschilds of the East.

Click on this link.. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Alfred_Ezra

My memory is that he was just a very sweet old man.

In future chapters I will talk about some of the other characters I encountered.

Dark times for many. Stay strong. Keep a diary and write up your story for your kids and friends.

**Dear friends,**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT, PAGE 4 part 2.**

**THE DUKE OF BEDFORD AND SOME FISHY TALES**

**Before I start I would just like to share some thoughts with you this Sunday morning.**

**The Corona virus news is getting grimmer every day, and is likely continue getting worse for a while yet. A sister of one of my friends died of it last week, a close friend is recovering from it and a son of other close friends has just contracted it.**

**Times are going to be very very hard in lots of ways.**

**We can all look back over our lives and remember the grimmest times we have gone through. 22 years ago we lost our most wonderful, vibrant daughter, very suddenly. It was too dreadful for words, yet life went on, and some positive things even came out of it.**

**Bad times are nothing new in the history of mankind. I fear as a civilisation we thought we were somehow immune. We are not, and we are not as clever as we perhaps like to think we are.**

**In 1969 I spent several months on Lake Chad. This story will feature later in my ramblings. My only companion was my 'boss', a woman twice my age who on top of serious 'gender identification' issues was also suffering from PTSD. I was the constant target of her wrath. It was the most horrible experience imaginable.**

**During that period I came across a text which helped me immeasurably, and helped me to survive. The verse was from the New Testament, (Hebrews 12, v.11) It says.....**

**"Now no chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous: nevertheless afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness unto them which are exercised thereby."**

**That is the King James version. A more modern translation says....**

**"We don't enjoy being disciplined. It always seems to cause more pain than joy. But later on, those who learn from that discipline have peace that comes from doing what is right."**

**For my twopenny worth I would like to offer my own translation.**

**"Times like this are absolute hell. But if we can endure them , and do what we have to do, when we emerge at the other side we will have learned from them and be stronger as a result."**

**All I will add is that although it was very grim time for me, those few months on Lake Chad ultimately had a massive positive influence on my life.**

**Sorry. I am meant to be getting on with my narrative, but I just wanted to share those thoughts with you. I hope they offered you a little encouragement .**

**Love to you all.**

**Richard.**

**So here we go.....**

**THE DUKE OF BEDFORD AND SOME FISHY TALES.**

**My father had a number of hobbies. Sailing, which he was good at but seldom had a chance to enjoy. Jam, marmalade and chutney making, which he was good at and did regularly, but also he was a keen and competent fly fisherman.**

**Through the generosity and kindness of his friends and acquaintances he was often offered the chance of some excellent trout and salmon fishing - at a time when there seemed to be plenty of fish in the rivers.**

**As a boy I enjoyed fishing too, although nowadays I get more pleasure from fish-watching. (I will explain how this works in a later chapter.)**

**Father met many interesting people through his work at London Zoo. Some became friends such as Mr. Ezra. (Yesterday a friend told me how she was so fascinated about him that she Googled him and now "knows all about him")**

**There was also an old lady I would love know more about, but despite my best Googling efforts, I cannot find out anything about her. Miss Maud Nobel lived on the Camden Town side of Primrose Hill. When you knocked on her door you might have thought it was Battersea Dogs home from the noise. The door would be opened by her maid, but then the diminutive Miss Nobel would come down the passage surrounded by a flock of about a dozen Pekinese, all yapping and skidding around her.**

**That was nothing compared with what was to come. Turn left into the large front room and you were confronted by literally dozens of cages of parrots of every shape and size. At the time it was almost impossible for an ordinary mortal to tell whether Amazon parrots were male or female, but Miss Nobel was of the few people who apparently could. Some year later technology made it easy. An endoscope was inserted down below and if there were ovaries, the bird was without doubt a lady! (They don't like it up'em in Cpl. Jones' immortal words.)**

**But now we come to the Duke of Bedford.**

I cannot remember ever meeting him, but he was a keen naturalist and ornithologist, and also happened to own the Woburn Estate. If you are curious to know more about him just Google '12th Duke of Bedford'.

No mention was ever made of Duke's involvement with far right politics but in 1953 I remember being told he had died in a shooting accident. The story I was given was that a sparrow hawk was preying on his free flying flock of Budgerigars and as he was climbing over a style with a loaded shotgun he ended up shooting himself. That might have been easier for a six year old to accept than the full truth 'whatever that was' as our heir to throne might say.

On the Woburn estate there are number of lakes, and one day my father took me out fishing on the largest lake in front of the Abbey. I was only tiny, but the fish he caught seemed to be monsters, and vicious. Years later my father told me they were Zander, also known as Pike-perch. Predatory and pretty ferocious. They were interesting times.

Some time after this we went back to Woburn for an entirely different kind of fishing. In the Chinese garden there was an ornamental pond teeming with large Golden Carp. We were setting off to catch a dozen of them for another zoo. 'Where is the rod?' I asked my father. 'We don't need a rod, the fish are so tame we just need my landing net' he replied.

This turned out to be a significant underestimation of their intelligence because as soon as the landing net was deployed the fish kept their distance, despite being tempted by the last of our white bread bait.

So it was back to London and a return trip the following week, armed with a rod and line.

Never has fishing been so easy. The moment the bread touched the water a feeding frenzy occurred and within no time had a dozen large fish in the tank of water we had in the back of the estate car.

However, among the massive carp there two tiny ones. Well, relatively tiny compared to the carp, maybe about five or six inches long. David and I were told we could have them if we could catch them. This proved to be challenging. We had to wait until they were well away from the monsters, then cast accurately to give them a chance to take the bait. Time and again, just as the target fish was about to take the bait a big one beat him to it. I cannot think of any other fishing experience when one was annoyed to catch the larger fish. Finally we were successful and the two goldfish lived for many years in a tank in our garden in London.

Another chapter on fish and fishing will have to wait.

This is George's obituary written by Biddy Baxter, Blue Peter's iconic editor for many years who knew him very well.

Some of what is written you may have read before, but there are lot of other snippets worth learning about.

Quite an inspiration I think you will agree.

**George Soper Cansdale, zoologist and broadcaster: born Brentwoood, Essex 29 November 1909; Colonial Forest Service, Gold Coast 1934-48; Superintendent, Zoological Society of London 1948-53; married 1940 Margaret Sheila Williamson (died 1992; two sons); died Great Chesterford, Essex 24 August 1993.**

**FOR ANY child watching Blue Peter during the Sixties, Seventies and most of the Eighties, George Cansdale was television's zoo man - the large, avuncular studio guest who would show the presenters how to bath six-foot pythons, produce bush-babies from his trouser pockets and tarantulas out of his turn-ups.**

**Children loved him because he was quirky, authoritative and uncondescending. Presenters from Valerie Singleton and John Noakes to Sarah Greene, Simon Groom and Peter Duncan admired him as an expert and a true professional. Cansdale was guaranteed to provide riveting viewing. If it crawled, slithered, flew, climbed or swam, he would bring it to the studio. Often his fingers were ominously covered with bloody bits of Elastoplast - he was intrepid when it came to handling the most dangerous animal and could never quite understand when a presenter flinched as a snake lunged or an orang-utan bared its teeth.**

**Generations of directors were kept on their toes because Cansdale, whose knowledge was vast, rarely did the same thing in the same order twice. During the 'live' transmissions there would be agonised cries: 'He's put the rat in the other pocket', or 'The skink's going up his trousers instead of down his sleeve]' The production team may have been reduced to jelly, but Cansdale remained imperturbable. Just what you would expect from a man who had flown from Singapore to London with poisonous snakes in his pyjamas. 'They had to be kept warm, they were perfectly safe in my hand baggage,' he pointed out.**

**George Cansdale was born in 1909 in Brentwood, Essex. The son of a clerk in a City shipping office, he won a scholarship to Brentwood School. His chief interest as a boy was ornithology, but as a student at St Edmund Hall, Oxford, reading for a forestry degree, he broadened his outlook and spent an extra couple of years doing his B Sc, followed by training for the Colonial Service.**

**In 1934, he was appointed Forest Officer for the Gold Coast, which was where he started collecting animals. It happened almost by chance. A friend working for Paignton Zoo begged him to bring home as many specimens as he could, on his next leave. Because his forestry work was so time-consuming, Cansdale, who was fluent in Tui, one of the main languages, enlisted the help of the local children he knew at the big government school on his station. He improvised travelling boxes from old petrol tins and their wooden containers and the 80 specimens included squirrels, hornbills, owls, touracos and snakes. This was when he had what he later described as his only 'serious' accident with animals - the first poisonous snake he had ever handled alive.**

**A boy brought him a small black snake held in the split end of a stick - not more than a third of a metre long and thinner than a finger. Although Cansdale picked it up correctly, behind the head, it bit the top of his left index finger. Unfortunately for him it was a burrowing viper - one of the very few snakes that cannot be picked up by hand as its lengthy fangs can strike however it is held.**

**In spite of his cutting the bite, letting it bleed and applying a tourniquet, by nightfall the fingertip had turned grey. Gradually it rotted off and the finger healed - nearly half an inch short. Cansdale felt he had**

had a lucky escape and it certainly didn't put him off collecting. He built up his own small zoos at his various jungle stations and they were so popular with the local inhabitants he had to fix regular opening hours. Whole classes of small children used to visit from schools in the towns too; most of them were seeing forest creatures alive for the first time in their lives.

Cansdale trained teams of boys to help him collect live specimens for zoos abroad and also to prepare skins for museums. They recorded many 'firsts' for West Africa, including two new species, a bat and a flying squirrel, eight snakes not previously recorded for the Gold Coast, and a huge black cobra found in a heap of rubbish in the office yard 8ft 8in long - nearly a foot longer than the previous best for West Africa. As well as supplying London Zoo he was able to offer animals to the Dublin and Edinburgh Zoos when they were restocking after the Second World War.

In 1940, George Cansdale married Sheila Williamson, who had been a fellow-student at Oxford, and thus began a perfect partnership that lasted almost 52 years. They first met in 1933 and as well as a mutual interest in wildlife they were both committed Christians. Sheila led a Bible study group for 30 years after returning to the UK and from 1950 to 1971 George was Churchwarden of All Souls' Langham Place. A Vice-President of the evangelical Crusaders Union, he spoke frequently at Crusader classes, churches and other Christian groups - often accompanied by Percy and Polly, his pet python and bush-baby.

It was while he was home on leave in 1947 that George Cansdale was headhunted by the Zoological Society of London. He was asked if he would take over as Superintendent from Dr Gwynne Vevers, who was about to retire. It was an inspired choice, for, in addition to his lifelong study of animals, as a Forest Officer Cansdale had added accounting, publicity, staff management, building, roadmaking and the care of trees to his skills. He held this post for five years from May 1948, but they were far from happy ones. He was quick to discover a hornet's nest of mismanagement and dishonesty and his efforts to stop the malpractices met with robust opposition from nearly all quarters.

His detective work began with the turnstile staff. He soon realised their style of living was vastly above their weekly wage packets. One man had a palatial house in Bedford and would take taxis to and from the station to the zoo. Cansdale estimated at least 10 per cent of London Zoo's income was being fiddled away by the turnstile cheats. When he changed the system there was an uproar.

On querying bills for the animals' food he discovered most of the keepers thought taking home bags full of fresh fruit and vegetables a legitimate perk. One man even had a profitable line in selling off the zoo's bedding- out plants - he supplied the best fuchsias in Camden and made a considerable income.

One of Cansdale's most extraordinary pieces of detection happened quite by chance. He was very much a 'hands on' Superintendent, spending just as much time out and about in the zoo as in his office. Late one night he decided to visit the reptile house. It was pitch dark and when he switched on the light he discovered the whole floor area obliterated by a seething mass of cockroaches. Appalled by this lack of hygiene he ordered an immediate de-infestation. To his amazement the keepers objected to any kind of clean-up. 'Oh well,' he was eventually told by the one security officer who was on his side, 'they're selling 'em for sixpence each]' The reptile house at London Zoo had been turned into a very lucrative cockroach breeding centre.

'There was no support from the Duke of Devonshire, President of the Council,' Cansdale said ruefully, years later. 'They didn't want a fuss.' And the Council took a time- honoured easy way out, by abolishing

**the post of Superintendent in 1953. Greatly to his credit, Cansdale was not bitter about his shabby treatment. But he was distressed that dishonesty had won the day and saddened that one of the world's most prestigious zoos appeared doomed to remain inefficiently managed.**

**It was during his years as Superintendent that Cansdale began to broadcast, for television, from the BBC's Alexandra Palace studios and later Lime Grove: he was a household name in the Fifties long before his Blue Peter appearances. His series of animal programmes included Popular Animal Fallacies, Heads, Tails and Feet, Looking at Animals and All About Animals. These last two series won him the Royal Television Society's Silver Medal in 1952. There were outside broadcasts from the zoo itself (Wynford Vaughan Thomas was bitten by a large Indian gecko, during a relay from the reptile house.) For radio too, Cansdale was a regular contributor to Children's Hour.**

**In the 1990s, with its plethora of wildlife programmes offered by all channels, this may seem unremarkable, but they all owe a debt to George Cansdale. He was a pioneer of scientific broadcasting and a tribute to his work in this field was paid by Sir David Attenborough in 1992, in his presidential address at the AGM of the British Association. 'A lot of thinking people, in those early days, took a fairly lofty view of television, regarding it as so populist as to be beneath their notice.' But natural history programmes started off with a thoroughly scientific base and Attenborough said it was thanks to Cansdale's bringing animals to the studios from London Zoo 'that a great many people, young and old, acquired their first insights into taxonomy and comparative anatomy from what he said. He spoke good natural science.'**

**In addition to broadcasting, Cansdale lectured and wrote many books. Early titles included Animals of West Africa (1946), Animals and Man (1952), George Cansdale's Zoo Book (1953), Belinda the Bushbaby (written with Sheila, 1953), Reptiles of West Africa (1955) and Behind the Scenes at a Zoo (1965). West African Snakes published in 1961, remains the standard work on the subject and was reprinted in 1992. Animals of Bible Lands (1965) entailed a study of every animal name in the Bible's Hebrew and Greek texts from the 'moving creature' of Genesis I to the figurative 'dogs' of Revelation 22. Cansdale described it as 'a fascinating task', but he was the first writer for over a century to attempt such a colossal project. His wife was an invaluable ally in this enterprise and in 1960 they spent a month wandering through the Lebanon, Syria, Jordan and Israel and toured Israel again in 1962.**

**Cansdale's energy and versatility were legendary. In the 1960s he became Director of Morecambe's Marine Land, Chessington Zoo and Natureland in Skegness. It was whilst he was with Natureland that he pioneered a way of obtaining clean seawater by drawing it through the sand in the beach. Realising this idea could be adapted to provide clean water in developing countries, he set up SWF Filtration Ltd with his younger son, Richard, to make the necessary filters. The company won a World Business Award (the IBM Award for Sustainable Development) in 1990.**

**Throughout his career as a scientist, broadcaster, writer, lecturer and inventor Cansdale always empathised with and had time for children. His cottage in Essex became a magnet for the village children as well as his much-loved grandchildren. The treat was accompanying Cansdale to the Blue Peter studio - one or sometimes two at a time, so there was a lengthy waiting list and Cansdale administered a rota with typical impartiality. Nine was the magic age when he allowed his young friends to join him and assorted wildlife and a boot-full of garden produce on the journey to Television Centre. 'Mr Cansdale, I'm nine next month - can I go with you, please' was the constant cry.**

Cansdale would always telephone in advance, and invariably the message would be the same. 'I'll come to the office first, I've a basket of windfalls - a load of beetroot and flowers. Oh yes, and there's some chutney and marmalade for you.' And a cornucopia of goodies would appear - enough for every member of the production team. There was never a more generous or warm-hearted contributor or one who produced more delicious jams and chutneys.

There was no so-called 'retirement' - even when an unlucky fall in 1991 resulted in a badly fractured femur, hospitalisation and a long and painful convalescence. His letter to the Telegraph in June of that year contributed to the debate on the current London Zoo controversy. He bitterly disagreed with the Grade I listings of the Penguin Pool and the Gorilla House - pointing out they were not designed with animals in mind. He also criticised the Snowdon Aviary and the Elephant House - in his eyes neither of them merited retention.

Cansdale triumphed over many vicissitudes, including the loss of part of his foot in the early Eighties as a result of skin cancer from his years in the tropics. But the cruellest blow of his whole life was the death, in March last year, of his beloved Sheila. Never in robust health, she had suffered from various illnesses for many years. But for the last two years of her life she was nursed devotedly by George.

He continued to live life to the full - despite problems with his broken femur that put a stop to his driving. Neighbours and his sons David and Richard and their wives, to whom George was devoted, rallied round but he was resolutely independent - accepting help with the garden but continuing with his chutney-making and his support for Inter-Care, a charity collecting medical items for African Mission hospitals. He regularly accumulated monthly parcels worth pounds 200 - typically thinking of others, rather than himself, to the very end.

Good morning,

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 5

I am very frustrated. I completed this morning's story, but when I hit the 'Post' button, it didn't respond for a few moments, but then when I thought it had, the text disappeared and hasn't been seen again.

So I will just smile and start all over again....

Preamble.

WALKS can take a number of different forms. Some are exploratory; you don't quite know where they will lead, but for others you can have a guide who will point things and tell you stories along the way.

I have just realised my ramblings are both, simultaneously. For me they are the former. I am delving into my memories and seeing where they lead; but you are joining me and I will share stories along the way. So hopefully this will be a win win situation for us all.

Today I wanted to explore my father's very first involvement with television. Before writing I had to do a little research to check my facts, but I am now quite confident that I have pieced the bits of the jigsaw together.

1948 was the year my father left his job as a forestry officer in the Gold Coast (which from now on I will refer to Ghana) and took up the post of Superintendent of London Zoo.

BBC had starting television broadcasting in 1936, then after a gap during the years of the Second World War, resumed again in 1946. In 1948, soon after joining the zoo George contributed to 'Picture Post', a programmed the BBC describe as the word's first Magazine Programme. He showed a squirrel.

I can only guess at this, but I suspect the squirrel would have been one from his animal collection in Ghana. If he had handled it since it was very young he could sure it would be well behaved. and because he knew his subject well, and was so enthusiastic, he would have been relaxed and confident and come across well. That is how within a very short time he came to be presenting his own animals for children, namely 'Looking at Animals' and 'All about Animals'. In 1952 the Television Society honoured his work by awarding him their medal for the best programmes of that year.

Then for a few years he did little television work, but when Blue Peter started he was the natural choice for its regular guest presenter for animal topics. He contributed numerous times to Blue Peter right up to the 1980's.

For someone else's perspective do read the obituary Biddy Baxter, the former iconic Blue Peter editor, wrote for The Independent when George died in 1984 aged 83.

* * * * *

I will now post this, and also post the text of Biddy Baxter's Obituary for your interest. Or I will TRY to!

or, here is a link to it....

https://www.independent.co.uk/…/obituary-george-cansdale-14…

WAS I THE VERY FIRST THEME PARK VISITOR EVER?

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT PAGE 6

In the messages which followed my last posting I was asked about what I think of as the Blue Peter elephant's water skiing incident. The baby elephant,Lulu, came from Chessington Zoo where father was a Director. I think he facilitated the elephant's day trip to London, but he was not in the studio for the water works.

When he had a Directors' meeting at Chessington my brother David and I often accompanied him. (If you are reading this now David - don't worry I'm not going to tell the Cockatoo story, or at least not today!)

No, on this particular day, when I was about ten, I was alone. In addition to the animals there were other attractions. I remember the Hall of Mirrors, the Ghost Train, the Helter Skelter to name a few. To go into these attractions you had to pay sixpence or a shilling but Harry Snazle, the Managing Director wrote a note and told me to show to the ticket collectors. Instead of paying for every ride, I had a brilliant time going as often as I wanted on all of them. I can still remember telling Mr. Snazle what fun I had had.

Had he decided to set a fixed price for visitors to allow them to go on all the rides as often as they wanted, he would have been 30 years ahead of the game. So, no, I don't think I can seriously claim to be the first Theme Park visitor.

I have just Google 'History of Chessington Zoo' and found this statement. "In 1987 the new park development adopted a pay-once price structure as opposed to the fairground's former pay-per-ride format." This was when the zoo became Chessington world of Adventures.

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT page 7.

Walks of Life.

**I had never given much thought to the expression "Different Walks of Life" before. Even during our nation's confinement due to the Corona virus pandemic we are being urged to exercise for he sake of our health. What are we allowed to do? Cycle, run or walk I think.**

**Some people stride out to get the heart pumping. What do they call it? Power walking. I prefer to stroll, binoculars around my neck just watching, thinking and exploring. I am so lucky to be living in Hartburn, because there is so much to see. Yesterday my friendly fox was there again. I watched him moving around and then curl up tightly against the chill wind.**

**I see the dippers every day. I knew they nested in the rocks but it was because I have had the time to watch them this spring, I have now spotted exactly where the nest is.**

**Yesterday I likened my writing to an exploratory walk for me, but a guided walk for you, then late last night, just before coming to bed I was delighted to discover, quite by chance, where the tame tiger my father used to stroke came from. (In my very first post I talked about the day my brother David and I climbed over the safety barrier and got much too close the tiger, and as a result got into big trouble.)**

**I can tell you how I this came about. I went up into my study to look out some pictures to add to today's post. Biddy Baxter, in George's obituary referred to his controversial departure from the zoo so I thought I would include an amusing cartoon which touched on this. The caption reads "Is that the Zoo? This is Viscount Chaplin's residence." (Please don't ask me to explain. Without some further research I really don't know what the significance is at present.) While looking out the original art work for the cartoon, I found a picture of George with the tiger in question, and then with it a collection of animal stories for children. One of these is the story of Baccha the tiger cub. I suddenly remembered the tiger was not Rajah, it was BACCHA, (Pronounced Barcher.)**

**The story explains how Baccha was found as an orphaned cub by a patrol of British Soldiers in the jungle in Malaya. It was emaciated and starving, taken back to show their colonel, and rescued from certain death. It was raised as a pet, but then sent back to London Zoo. By now it was getting quite large, but it was not thriving. It was getting thinner. It was then realised he was depressed and missed human company, but when this was rectified he recovered and did well. He then lived in the Lion House at the Zoo, but it recognised my father in crowd, who would regularly stroke him through the bars.**

**So, perversely, as a direct result of this dreadful pandemic, I have embarked on a voyage of discovery which I may never have got round to had it not been for my involuntary self-isolation. It would be lovely to think you are enjoying reading my stories as much as I am writing them. Goodness only knows what I will discover.**

**Or, as someone often accused of having an obsession with my stove can say "It's an ill wind that blows nobody any WOOD."**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. Page 8.**

**Good morning all,**

**If I was to say "Good evening all!" I wonder how many of you would know whose catch phrase that was?**

**Dixon of Dock Green was a TV police series, introduced by a character George Dixon, played by the actor Jack Warner. It was first screened in 1955 and ran for 432 episodes until 1976 amazingly.**

**I have only just realised this, but a few of you have mentioned my preambles before I start my story of the day. That was just how the Dixon of Dock Green stories were introduced.**

**This morning I will touch on hate mail, and how George responded to it. A curious topic you might think - but nothing new.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. Page 8.**

**Two evenings ago when I looked out the Tiger pictures I also found the cartoons I have included today. I particularly like the bear one. You will see there is no mention of George's name. There was no need because by now he was such a well known face.**

**It is hard to credit it, but there was only one television channel at that time, and it only broadcast for a few hours a day, so no choice whatsoever. I suppose it was a bit like the Monty Python SPAM sketch. What if you don't like spam?**

**We all tend to warm to some people and not to others. It is a natural human instinct, but then the extreme version of this is the vile habit of on-line abuse. As I said, this phenomenon is not new but in father's day people would write nasty anonymous letters.**

**Father's response was to file them under the "FUNNY LETTERS" and with much amusement quote them when the occasion arose. One of his favourites I can quote almost verbatim. (I have toned it down slightly so as not to cause offence.) It said this.....**

**"Mr. Cansdale, Every time I see your **** features on television it makes me want to throw up. I was so sorry that the fruit bat bit your finger. I wish it had been your throat!"**

**There must be any number of reasons why people write letters like, and I know it is really horrible to be on the receiving end of them, but father's way of coping with them was classic.**

**Have you wondered why I should have given my ramblings the working titled of "Third cage on the left?" I will soon be telling you how having just turned eight, I was sent to a boarding Prep school in Sussex. Sounds inhumane doesn't it, and I was teased for having grown up in a zoo, but as I have already said, I put it down to jealousy and laughed it off.**

**But for all the nasty letters there were countless positive ones. I think he replied to each and every one.**

**When we moved from London Zoo, it was only a few miles to Lyndale Avenue in NW2. Number 45 is a six bedroom semi-, which allowed father to have a live-in secretary and my mother to have an au pair girl to help her. With David and me too, it was quite a busy household.**

**So what was my father to do now? He had lost his salaried post at the zoo, so his departure offered new opportunities. I don't think he was ever worried about any shortage of work because he now embarked on writing, lecturing and public speaking, zoo work and still some television appearances. He also had time for hobbies, charity work, and for 25 years he was a Church Warden at All Souls Langham Place. If all that doesn't make you feel exhausted, it does me!**

**I will stop now and have some breakfast.**

**Just one more think. If you are able to read the letter below, look at the small print a the top of the page! One word sticks out as such a strange choice of language. See if you can spot it. I don't know if there will be sufficient definition, but it amused me.**

**Hang on in there every one. Grim times. Do those things you aways promised yourself you would do. That's why I am boring you with my ramblings.**

**Have a nice day. x**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. Page 8.**

**Preamble.**

**Yesterday were were told 562 people had died from the Covid-19 virus in the previous 24 hours. We are living in such a dreadful worrying time and are all having to draw on all of our resources as individuals, as families and as a nation.**

**I am sure there are countless others like me, who are over 70 and have been told to self-isolate, who are being supported by friends and family who are shopping for us; phoning us regularly to check we are ok, as well as trying to work if they can and looking after their own family. Thank you each and every one. That is on top of our massive debt of gratitude to the self-sacrificing work being done by our wonderful NHS staff.**

**I started writing my personal story two and a half weeks ago after sharing coffee with my friend Pam who went down with the virus the following day. I am pleased to say she is recovering, but has had a very nasty time. I am keeping very well, so probably did not get the virus, but who knows? We are told**

many have no symptoms whatsoever. I did have a very slight tight chest for a few days which I can no longer feel. Was that the virus?

Some of you are dipping into these ramblings over your morning coffees today, April 2nd 2020, perhaps some are reading these words years after the Coronavirus Pandemic of 20202 has slipped into history.

At this present time we have no idea what the future will hold for us or how long the pandemic will last. Just a few short weeks ago we were worried sick about global warming and what we humans have done to our beautiful planet by greed and over consumption. Today the airlines are all but grounded. The larges cities are in lock-down and our roads are silent. We are having a massive wake up call. Is this our planet revenge?

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Today my story will see the family leaving London Zoo and moving to NW2. Just before we do I am attaching a photograph of some people walking through a tunnel.

Can you guess where this is?

A few years ago I was watching a documentary on London Zoo when I saw a clip of the tunnel in which I had my tricycle accident in 1952. I froze the picture and took a snap of it. My crash was on the left just at the start of the rounded arch.

I found the photo while looking for some pictures to accompany today's post but to save time now I will post the preamble and then post the main story hot off the press later.

Keep strong and stay safe.

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT. Page 8.

PETS AT HOME

In 1953 our move from the Zoo to NW2 was only a few miles. Walking distance from Hampstead heath, but on a route which offered equally good access to the West End and to open countryside.

This six bedroom semi- accommodated the family, my father's live-in secretary, my mother's European au pair girl but in the custom built, insulated shed in the garden, my father's collection of pets. Some common, some exotic.

In the house was our much loved tabby cat, Popa, named after the Mexican volcano, Popocataptl, and the Liisa, the Finnish Spitz. A lovely dog, but its other name of the Finnish Barking Dog should have warned us that it was perhaps not the best choice when surrounded by neighbours. In Finland they run ahead of hunters and bark at base of trees into which game birds have sought sanctuary.

In the dining room was my budgie and a re-homed African Grey Parrot. In the drawing room my brother had tropical fish, and in the garden itself one or two tortoises, The Blue Peter tortoises lived with us; First there was 'Fred' He became 'Freda' when he, sorry she, laid an egg. For a while the second Blue Peter, George also lived with us. After the fishing expedition to the Woburn Chinese Garden pond, the two anonymous gold fish joined the family.

It was in the garden shed where things started to get more interesting. The cages always contained a range of common pets, Netherland Dwarf rabbits, Guinea pigs and White and Hooded Rats.

There were always at least two snakes. A Royal Python, also known as the Ball Python, with its most beautiful markings, and an African Python, which tended to grow and grow and grow. These were joined by a Boa Constrictor. All of the snakes were handled regularly and taken by my father when he spoke to schools, clubs or Women's Institutes etc.

The star of the show was Polly, my father's Bush Baby. My father had Polly for many years and she made countless appearances at father's lectures. If the audience was large he would take Polly to the back of

**the hall and put her on someone's shoulder. He then walked to the front of the hall, where Polly would rejoin him having jumped from shoulder to shoulder the entire length of the hall.**

**Those were the residents. We then entertained 'animals in transit'. B&B you could say - in boxes or behind bars! You never quite knew who would turn up, or how they would arrive. It seemed that anyone with an animal they no longer wanted would ask George to re-home them.**

**On day a couple turned up with a monkey. The wife was in tears as she got into the car to leave, but before her husband left he whispered into my father's ear, "I'm so glad to be shot of that wretched creature. She would bring it to bed with her!"**

**I have just remembered how one of the tortoises arrived. It just had a piece of newspaper taped around its shell with the head and tail poking out at either end. I cannot recall who delivered it, but I think it was the postman himself. Full marks for imagination to the sender. It was better than dumping it as some irresponsible exotic pet owners do today.**

**Although it was my father's secretary who helped look after the animals in term time, when David and I were at home we helped too. Father was a keen gardener so all the soiled bedding went on the compost heap. Horse drawn carts were still used by the rag and bone men, the recycling operatives of the day, and from time to time they would come round offering a load of manure for gardens. We delighted in saying 'We make our own!" which never failed to raise their eyebrows.**

**One weekend we looked after a lion cub in transit to another zoo. Then for a few days a delightful black bear cub was staying. He was very tame and could be walked on a lead. The current au pair girl was animal mad and took it for a walk to the shops on Finchley Road. She returned home in tears.**

**Apparently nobody had shown any interest in young bear even when she started stopping people and telling them what she had. I still think it was so strange.**

**One day a new au pair girl had just arrived. It was a warm summer day and we were having a cup of tea in the garden. Suddenly she too burst into tears! A tortoise was approaching her chair.**

**To my mother's horror she realised she had forgotten to mention we had animals, and this poor girl appeared to have an animal phobia. The offending tortoise was removed to a safe distance and since by good fortune we didn't have any animals in house itself at that particular time there was a possibility things might still work out, provided no mention was made of some of the residents in the Animal House.**

**In the event, an animal-free family was located and the lass would go to them after a couple of weeks. During this time she actually got used to the tortoise and was not bothered by the fact that there were animals in the garden shed. She didn't need to go in there. It was shortly before leaving that she discovered the awful truth. "You never told me you had SNACKS!" were her immortal words.**

**It was sad that a few days later she did move on because by then she was already less worried by the snakes in the shed and given a little more time she may well have stayed. On a number of occasions father cured people of their irrational fear of snakes, but you can't win them all.**

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**So let's take a break.**

**A few picts to make you smile.**

**Good morning dear friends,**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT PAGE 8 Part 2**

**PETS LEAVING HOME.**

**I cannot believe that things will ever be the same after the Pandemic. Even when we pass the peak of infections we won't know for a long time how long it will be beforesome form of normality return.**

**Until recently on clear mornings I would often see half a dozen vapour trails criss-crossing the sky. For the last couple of weeks I have not seen one, but a few minutes ago I looked up to see a single east-bound one from the bathroom window.**

**So much has changed in world since we were born, and even more during our parents lifetimes. Travel, communication, health and photography to name just a few. Will we change how we expect to be able to travel so much in future, pumping CO2 into the atmosphere. I wonder.**

**Zoos too have had to change, and if you are thinking "Good job too" I couldn't agree with you more. They had too, and they have, thank goodness. I will be exploring this subject at some stage.**

**I am getting a little ahead of myself, let me tell you about a few incidents I recall from our time in Lyndale Avenue.**

**I had been given my first Budgie by Mr. Palmer, proprietor of his big pet shop in Camden Town. He was blue (the Budgie, not Mr. Palmer), and I called him Winky. In time Winky died and was replaced by a Grey green budgie, Smokey. One day I was in front of the house only to see Smokey sitting on the fence like a mugwump. (I'll explain in moment if you've not heard of a mugwump.)**

**I didn't want him to fly off so I approached him slowly, offered up my finger, and as he alighted I deployed my thumb to hold him down - and I had him. I took him into the house, only to find Smokey was still in his cage! It wasn't Smokey at all. I now had two. I think we must have put a sign on the gate telling people that we had found him because we didn't keep him long. No social media in those days.**

**Unlike today, house sparrows were very common in our gardens. Their cheeky chirping call was imitated by the budgies who I suppose had Cockney accents. The sparrow caused havoc in my dad's vegetable garden, so he gave me an air rifle. Did a lot of target practice but the best way to scare off the spuggies for me to place old tin cans and buckets in the garden and then fire at these targets.**

**On hot days the Animal house doors and windows were left wide open, and one day the Royal Python was missing. Strangely its tank lid was still secure, but we searched high and low to no avail. All the pythons were called Percy, plus an adjective. This was handsome Percy.**

**A few months later I went into the Animal House. The doors and windows were closed, and there, curled up on top of the snakes' tank was Percy. He was in good condition and must have been returned by the thief. A mystery we never solved, but I wonder if someone in the thief's family discovered where he had come from and demanded the perpetrator took it back. Years later I had another stolen item returned in the strangest of circumstances. That can wait for another day.**

**Almost forgot. Mugwumps? “The first political mugwumps were Republicans in the presidential race of 1884 who chose to support Democratic candidate Grover Cleveland rather than their own party’s nominee. Their independence prompted one 1930s humorist to define mugwump as ‘a bird who sits with its mug on one side of the fence and its wump on the other’.”**

**David had his tank of tropical fish in the drawing room and from time to time we went to the pet shop in Hendon to get some new ones. To collect them, and keep the water warm for the journey home we filled one of our mother's shopping bags with large glass Kilner jars, plus a hot water bottle for warmth.**

**The bag was quite heavy so we had a handle each.**

**The bus stop on the Hendon Way, a dual carriageway, was about one hundred yards short of a busy intersection with Cricklewood Lane. As we waited to cross the dual carriageway we saw the bus coming down from Finchley road, but we didn't get to the bus stop in time. Luck was on our side because the lights turned red and the bus was forced to stop at the cross roads.**

**Not wanting to wait for next bus we sprinted for it. David was faster than me and leapt on board just as the lights turned green. He held onto the pole with one hand and the bag handle with the other but the bus was now travelling at a considerable speed. David pulled his handle as I pulled mine, and by a miracle I took a final leap onto the bus' platform. Exhausted and out of breath I collapsed onto down a back seat.**

**I'll finish this morning with another bus story which involved David, myself and my maternal Grandmother we called Banan.**

**I much preferred the buses to the tubes because you could see where you were going. How to work out where a particular tue was going baffled me for years. So to the next bus story.**

**The three of us had been in the West End and were walking to the bus stop when a bus came past us and stopped. We all ran for it, Banan included who was in her early eighties at the time.**

**(She lived until she was 99, and the very first time Sue met her she wanted to show us a badger sett, which involved all of us climbing over a barbed wire fence, so she was up for it!)**

**This time I was the first one to board, but at that point the bus started off. What could I do?**

**Luckily I knew the bell codes. One ring to tell the driver to stop at the next request stop. Two rings for him to start off again. Three rings meant "Full Right Up" which meant the driver would not stop at the next bus stop unless passengers were disembarking. But FOUR RINGS I knew was the emergency stop signal. I felt as if I had no alternative. I rang the bell four times. The bus stopped abruptly, and in the confusion David and Banan caught up and got on. The conductor was not at all pleased and was grumpy until just before we got off, but then just before we did, he changed his tune and said it was good of me to consider my grandmother.**

**INSTEAD OF .....THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT PAGE 8 part 3.....**

**This morning my lovely beautiful friend Kameel Towler has posted one of Sue's Poems on my timeline.**

**Thank you Kameel.**

**Later in my journal, if I am still alive, (which I still hope to be), I will write about 'Special People I have met along the way.' Kameel is one of those people.**

**Kameel stayed with us soon after Zoe died, and quickly became a close supportive friend. She has faced somany challenges in her life. The early loss a parent; the move from the Caribbean while still in her teens; health issues; and to cap it all, has been on the receiving end of institutionalised racism during her time in the prison service. Yet ALWAYS thinking of others, supporting friends and family thought thick and thin, and still smiling.**

**I have had the cushiest of lives in comparison. Kameel is one of our true heroes. So lovely friends. I will give you a break tis morning.**

**Contemplate Sue's Poem, then add some claps and hearts and hugs emoji for Kameel this morning.**

**She is as beautiful and as exotic a person as the Mandarine Duck is as a bird. The picture is one I took on Thursday afternoon of the resident Mandarine drake. I saw him and his missus flew up into to a tree. He he is in all his glory.**

**So hey, thanks Kameel for giving me a break. My post will follow in due course. Fear not.**

**Now some hugs and claps for Kameel and all your similarly supportive friends and family members. We need you now more than ever. THANK YOU ALL**

**Good Morning. While wishing Colleen Anderson 'Happy Birthday I read her post 'Just so I NEVER forget'. She has asked for it to be shared, so I am sharing it with you before I post my memories of being sent off to a boarding Prep school 65 years ago.**

**Just so I NEVER forget..... April 4, 2020**

**Diesel price at Morrison's was £1.10**

**School cancelled**

**GCSEs cancelled**

**A-Levels cancelled**

**Self-distancing measures on the rise.**

**Tape on the floors at shops to help distance shoppers (2m) from each other.**

**Limited number of people inside shops, therefore, lineups outside the doors.**

**Non-essential shops and businesses mandated closed.**

**Pubs, theatres, restaurants are closed.**

**Entire sports seasons cancelled.**

**Concerts, tours, festivals, entertainment events - cancelled.**

**Weddings, family celebrations, holiday gatherings - cancelled.**

**Churches are closed. Graveyards are shut.**

**Don't socialise with anyone outside of your home.**

**Children's outdoor play parks are closed.**

**We are to distance from each other.**

**Shortage of masks, gowns, gloves for our front-line workers.**

**Shortage of ventilators for the critically ill.**

**Panic buying sets in and we have no toilet paper, no disinfecting supplies, no paper towel no laundry soap, no hand sanitiser.**

**Bread, pasta, flour, eggs, chicken and chopped tomatoes are sold out everywhere**

**Shelves are bare.**

**Manufacturers, distilleries and other businesses switch their lines to help make visors, masks, hand sanitiser and PPE.**

**All non-essential travel banned.**

**Fines are established for breaking the rules. Police patrolling the streets.**

**Arenas open up for the overflow of Covid-19 patients.**

**Press conferences daily from the government.**

**The government throws money at businesses to try to keep the economy from imploding. Grants and loans. The government to pay 80% of employees wages where businesses cannot continue to do so.**

**Daily updates on new cases and deaths.**

**The dead are denied wakes or funerals and barely anyone is allowed at the graveside.**

**Barely anyone on the roads.**

**People wearing masks and gloves outside.**

**Essential key workers are terrified to go to work.**

**Medical field workers are afraid to go home to their families.**

**This is the Novel Coronavirus (Covid-19) Pandemic, declared March 11th, 2020.**

**Why, you ask, do I write this status?**

**One day it will show up in my memory feed, and it will be a yearly reminder that life is precious and not to take the things we dearly love for granted.**

**We have so much!**

**Be thankful. Be grateful.**

**Be kind to each other - love one another - support everyone.**

**Copy and share.**

**Good morning (again).**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT PAGE 8 part 3..**

**I have just copied a very moving post Colleen Anderson put on her timeline about the present situation. We are in very strange times and I am sure in the future people will ask, 'Was it really like that?'**

**In my post today I am looking back to 1955 when I was sent off to a Prep School in Sussex. To write it I had to explore my memories, which are still very vivid. I nearly bypassed this period entirely thinking nobody would be interested, but when I mentioned that to a close friend she said, 'No, I think people would like to know what it felt like for you.' So I give you a brief glimpse into the life of a rather wild little boy between the ages of eight and thirteen.**

**I wonder what you will make of it. Cruel or formative, or both?**

**You don't have to read all or any of it, but I wanted to commit it to paper while my memory allows.**

**Good luck, and do your best to enjoy this Sunday as best you can.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT PAGE 8 part 3.**

**For the first two years after moving to Lyndale Avenue I remained at my Primary School, North Bridge House. I have a handful of disjointed memories of this period. David had already left for Great Walstead, a boarding prep school near Haywards Heath in Sussex. One girl in his class was a certain Jane Asher, who achieved fame as an actor, a friend of Paul McCartney and the maker of wonderful decorated cakes, which Zoe emulated. My special friend at the time was Belinda, a class mate who I was very fond of when I was six and seven. I wonder if she is out there somewhere, but I fear, even if she is she wouldn't remember me.**

**For the next two years I traveled the three miles to and from school, alone on the London buses; from the age of just six. Would the parents of today allow that? I doubt it. I would pay my tuppence, and on way home hoped not to fall asleep because my stop, Child's Hill, was a request stop and I had to ring the bell to stop the bus. I have just remembered how one day when we were still at the zoo my mother came to collect me she took this little boy in his school uniform by the hand and led him off, only to realise to her horror she had hold of the wrong child. Do I recall a SpecSavers ad to that effect?**

**Before joining big brother David at Great Walstead my parents and I drove down to see him, as I recall it only once, or possibly twice a term, to take him out for day. I can't remember anything about the visits themselves but still recall all too clearly how we were involved in a nasty accident on the way home when a motorcycle drove into the back of our car at speed. The image is still clear in my mind. We were invited into a house for a cup of tea, and I am afraid the motocyclist lost his leg as a result of the accident. None of us was hurt but our car was a Morris Isis estate car with two backward facing seats in the very back of the car. I often sat there, pre-seat belts of course, but on that journey I opted for the standard back seat shortly before the crash. Had I not moved I would probably have been injured.**

**I had been very happy at North Bridge House, but being sent to a boarding school having just turned eight was..... Do you know I actually find it hard to find the right word. It was certainly a shock to the system, but I coped and soon settled in and started to enjoy the freedom which allowed us to roam freely on the school's farm and in the woods. I was one of only two new boys that summer term and given the number 81. The first time the number had been issued, so that term there were just 81 boys. While on the subject of numbers, a few days later I remember the teacher writing the date on the blackboard. It was 5th May 1955. 5/5/55. (Twenty two years later I taught my very last lesson on the 7th July 1977. 7/7/77.)**

**It was early that first term when I passed a hedge in which I saw two long tailed tits, so close I could almost touch them. What amazingly beautiful birds they were. This was my first, personal wildlife experience and the start of my love of birds.**

**I didn't appreciate it at the time, but this was not your average prep school. For example, if you broke a window - you mended it. You would be given glass of the right size, the putty and the necessary tools, and shown how to do it. I only had to repair a window once but the reason I recall it so clearly was because I cut my little finger very badly and it was only a few years ago when the scar eventually faded.**

**All the lawns around the school were mown by the boys using a variety of petrol engine mowers, which we also maintained. Boys from farming families drove the little grey Massey Fergie tractor towing its gang mower to cut the playing fields. The most lethal machine was an Allen Rototscythe. Two large tyre-less wheels drove this monster with a bar of vicious reciprocating triangular blades. At least the lack of a silencer meant you could hear it coming from a mile away and nobody, to the best of my memory, suffered a double foot amputation.**

**If that wasn't enough potential danger there was plenty more to come. We could use our axes to chop down silver birch trees to make camps and dens in the woods. Tree climbing was permitted, and it was a right of passage to climb to the top of the Big Fir, a mature Scots Pine tree close the school itself. I attach a photo I took from the top looking down onto the school. Some years before my arrival the headmaster, who by now you will have appreciated was a touch eccentric had constructed a mini-roller coaster, known as the Switchback. It was in a poor state of repair so not often used but there was still one potentially dangerous bit of fun to be had.**

**Mr Mowll, the Head, had stripped down an ancient car leaving just the wheels, the bare chassis and the steering column. From the school to the kitchen gardens there was a winding farm track with perfect gradient for this madness. Seven or eight of us would commandeer the chassis. With one boy steering and the rest of us hanging on for dear life, we would career down this track. We then pushed it back up the hill and repeated the exercise with another boy at the helm. Amazingly, I do not recall any significant accidents from our free range activities.**

**Up in the woods there was a tiny stream, not more than a trickle really. Here dam building was serious stuff. The older boys' earth dams were upstream so when they opened the flood gates the dams further downstream were inundated and destroyed.**

**I was far from academic. In fact without exception I was always one from the bottom of the class. Howard Smith III, so named because he had two older brothers at the school, was always bottom. (Not his real name.) By the same token I was Cansdale II, or 'Canny' to my friends. I thought being one from bottom was my pre-ordained position in life and I could to nothing to change it, so I didn't. It wasn't until I was about fourteen that I discovered that with hard work I could do a wee bit better.**

**The school was run as economically as possible. Mr. Mowll love auctions where he could buy up army surplus materials for knockdown prices. At one Prep School Headmasters' conference when all he other heads were complaining about having to put the fees UP, Mr. Mowll proudly boomed out "I have just put my fees DOWN!" Thinking back now, I suspect German or Italian prisoners of war might have had better rations than we did. Luckily the gaps in the floorboards in the 'Dining Room', in reality just a large shed, were wide enough to drop the slices of inedible cold beef through. There were few if any oversize boys in the school.**

**Sussex had been on the front line during the Second World war. Stories of the Doodlebugs, the VI flying bombs being intercepted overhead were still being told. One had allegedly landed in the local village duck pond. Instead of Cubs or Scouts, the school had its equivalent in the form of Mudlarks and Q Day. Q Day was a protracted war game on Wednesday afternoons. In the summer term, the climax was a 24 hour exercise when we slept in the camps we had been constructing. This was Q DAY itself. We never knew when it would be, but a code word was given to a senior boy, mid lesson, at which point he would shout out "Q Day!". School lessons would be abandoned and 24 hours of sleepless mayhem would follow. All good fun.**

**Despite all the freedom, discipline was surprisingly strict too, and misbehaviour was still generously rewarded with corporal punishment. Often it was deserved, but not always. One term there was a marbles craze. Everyone was playing marbles and if your were any good, you could build up a good collection. One evening, after lights out, I needed my handkerchief from the pocket of my shorts on the chair beside my bed. As I pulled the handkerchief out of the pocket all my marbles cascaded onto the**

**floor. A horrible shiny hardboard floor, no doubt the cheapest way to cover dormitory's old floorboards to avoid splinters. As my marbles rolled in every direction they made a terrible noise. A master had his bedroom next to our dorm. He stormed in, demanding to know whose marbles they were, and without any chance to explain I was slippered. Today that would be classed as an assault. 60 years ago it was part of the territory. We accepted the rough with the smooth. One boy was once playing with a toy aeroplane he had lovingly made from balsa wood during a lesson when the teacher caught him. His punishment? He was told to put in on the floor and stamp on it! Ouch. Harsh, but I bet he never did it again.**

**Curiously it was in that very same dormitory as the new term started that one of my pals produced a strip of material from his pocket and said "Look what my uncle has invented." It was strip of Velcro.**

**I was happy with the freedom but I did not thrive academically. The class I joined had studied French for two terms. I had none, so when in my very first French lesson I was asked to read aloud from the text book 'Ou est ma femme?' I tried my best and said 'Oo est mar femmy!' the class fell about laughing. There and then I decided 'French is most certainly not for me.' Latin was equally disastrous.**

**On balance, am I glad to have been sent away to school so young? Given the circumstances I guess I am. I preferred the countryside to life in London. My parents were both exceptionally busy, but in the holidays had plenty time to do things with us. They were loving and kind, and I am sure they did it for us and believed it would be good for us. I never once**

**abandoned.**

**One factor which I had forgotten all about until talking to David, which may well have had a bearing on their decision, was air quality.**

**London in the 50's and even the early 60's was plagued with smog, particularly in the winter. I only remember one really bad one, and that was before we left the zoo, but boy it was bad. It must have been the smog of December 1952 which lasted for five days. That year 10,000 people died in London from the air pollution. Some years later a newly arrived au pair asked my mother "Where is the fog?" Such was London's reputation at the time.**

**Good morning friends.**

**Computer Disaster. LOCK DOWN**

**Normally I write my next instalment first thing in the morning as I am drinking my bucket of tea, and then post it hot off the press.**

**Last night I thought I would be very virtuous and write it before going to bed. So I did. I then wanted to add just thee photos. One showed a selection of the articles my father had written for the Eagle comic; the next was the front of one of two Ladybird books he had written, and the third a screen shot of Chris Packham, the naturalist and broadcaster holding open the same book and explaining how as a boy that very book had inspired and excited him!**

**And then..... and then, the computer froze. It locked up totally. Not a single key responded. HELP!**

**Not only might I have to write it all again, but I had no copy of what I had written and it soon became clear my only option would be to turn the computer off and lose everything.**

**I explored the keyboard and pressed every key when suddenly the up and down arrow keys responded so I could now scrolll up and down to see what I had written. Did this offer a straw to clutch?**

**Welll, let me ask you. What would you have done a that point?**

**I would be curious to know, so please tell me.**

**OK, what did I do? A clue? L.T. Yes, Lateral Thinking. I asked myself 'Is there any way I can salvage my text and carry on with the computer locked?' Hold on, aren't we all in a lock down situation ourselves and are facing the same dilemma in our lives!!**

I had at least three options. I could copy it all out again onto paper. Do you remember in the old days we used to write lettes on paper? No time.

Or I could type it all out again? Too tired.

Any other options? Yes, one, and it was the one which sprang to mind. Perhaps I could photograph the screen and post the photos.

Thats what I did, so without further ado I will post this now in case it happens again and them post the photos in the next post. I will try to ensure you can read them in the correct order, or out of badness just post them at random! I'm sorry. they never quite managed to beat the mischief out of me at Prep School.

Bye for now..

I have now added the actual text for.....

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 8 part 4

The Eagle Has Landed; and family Fortunes

If you like jigsaws you will know that is only as you start fitting the pieces together that the picture starts to emerge. But then there is that irritating gap you just can't fill. You begin to think the piece you need has been lost, but suddenly there it is staring you in the face all along.

One of those missing pieces was the one which explained how my father was able to afford our school fees.

In the 1950s and 60s there was a popular comic called The Eagle. From the internet I have discovered…..

The Eagle, one of Britain's most famous and well remembered comics, was launched by Hulton Press on 14th April 1950. The brainchild of the Reverend Marcus Morris and artist Frank Hampson, Eagle was created to promote Christian values and provide an alternative to the American comics which Morris considered to be well produced but morally repugnant. The lead character, drawn by Hampson, was Dan Dare, a square-jawed space hero.

If you would like to know more here is a link……
https://britishcomics.fandom.com/wiki/Eagle_(Hulton_Press)

My father was a regular contributor to the Eagle, with half page articles which were all entitled “Nature had it First”. I used to read the comic, but to my shame I probably took my father's column for granted and went straight to the Dan Dare stories. One day, not long before he died my father remarked in passing that his work for the Eagle had paid for David's and my school fees

I have copies of most of the books he wrote but all of our ‘Eagles’ disappeared years ago. I felt bad about this and didn’t think I could do anything about it, but from time to time I buy things on eBay. If you type ‘Cansdale’ into the search bar and click on ‘Books, Comics and Magazines’ you'll instantly be offered scores of books, most but not, all written by George.

One day I want to buy a copy of his Ladybird Book of British Wild Animals. This has the most attractive paintings and was held up by Chris Packham at the very start of a recent programme documenting the history of Ladybird Books. To my delight and astonishment I saw someone was selling six of my father's articles from the Eagle. I messaged him and wondered if he would do a deal if I bought them all. He said he was very happy to do so, and then explained how he had been one of my father's fans and had cut out these articles from the Eagle comic years ago. He sent them to me but then a few weeks later he contacted me again offering me another 50 more for a nominal price. He then found the rest of his collection which he offered to me on the condition that they would be a gift and he wanted nothing for them. There are some wonderfully generous People out there.

Today I sorted them into their different categories. I now have 133 in all, covering British birds, Insects, Prehistoric Animals, Life Under the Sea and Pets. In fact there are only four ‘Nature Had it First’ articles which I had mistakenly thought were the majority. I feel humbled not just by his amazing breadth of

knowledge and his ability to share it so enthusiastically, but by the fact that all that hard work had funded my schooling. I hope we showed him our gratitude before he died

In my title for today's ramblings I included the words ‘Family Fortunes’.

My paternal grandfather was a Cockney who worked as a clerk for a shipping company in the London docks. His father had grown up on a farm in Essex but his experience with horses allowed him to get a job in London driving carts for the Royal Mail. But it was my grandfather's uncle’s job title which really takes the biscuit. When he was 14 there was a census in which his profession was stated as……..Well, I would really like you to have a guess. It is a job which while certainly important has perhaps the lowest status of all the jobs on the farm. I'll give you a clue. When I was working with African agricultural development projects I often saw small boys doing this job as harvest time approached.

I'll tell you “Rook Scarer”. My great great uncle was a Scarecrow!

The fact that within two generations my aunt, my two uncles and my father had all achieved significant success in their lives is a great tribute to my grandfather, a devout god-fearing man, who believed in the importance of education.

I will finish with an amusing conversation I had with my father after visiting my 94 year old grandfather at the care home he lived out his days at Frinton on the Essex coast.

I can work out his age because it was before I passed my test and I was driving my father’ Vauxhall VX 490. It was a nippy car and there was I, still with L plates and before any speed limits, driving at 80 mph most of the way back to London. Scary thought. Sorry, that is irrelevant to my story. The conversation went like this.

Father. “Grandpa is very worried what to do with his money.”

Me, slightly embarrassed at having to ask. “Is there very much?

Father. “About £4 7s 6d, or £4.37 in our coinage.

My father had very humble roots, which make his achievements all the more remarkable.

If you remember the Dan Dare stories you will remember the Mekon too.

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 8 part 5

(Unedited first draft - but something to get on with.)

For the record, today is Tuesday 7th March 2020. A couple of weeks ago Boris Johnson cheerfully told us he was experiencing 'mild symptoms' of the Coronavirus and was self-isolating. This morning he is in intensive care! We were told it was as a precaution, but I wonder.

Actions speak louder than words, so regardless of what you think of Boris, I just wonder if today the seriousness of the situation will really hit home.

So I need to press on with my stories. I am looking forward to telling you about how when I was a student I spent three summers working as a keeper in German zoos; about my months on Lake Chad and of some of my experiences in Africa, such as the day I was face to face with a family of Mountain Gorillas in what was Zaire. They will have to wait, but we'll get there in due course.

So here we go....

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 8 part 5.

PREP SCHOOL HIGH DAYS

Some people believe that I have a good memory for dates. They might have that impression because that several of the landmark dates in my life, by which I mean those key events involving house, school or job moves were actually on dates easy to remember. So my Great Walstead years were 1955-60, Monkton Combe 1960-65, London University and the Lake Chad Expedition 1965-1970. I actually flew home from Africa having left Lake Chat and hitch-hiked across the Sahara to Algiers on 1st January

**1970, so I might be able to remember easy things. Remembering to put things away in their right places is not.**

**While writing about my time at Great Walstead opened the door into more memories. When I joined the school as an eight year old there were only just over 80 pupils. It was more like an extended family and you very soon knew who everyone was.**

**Because very early on, probably from the very first week I had decided I was not very good at lessons, I don't think I was motivated to work hard. To have joined the school in the summer term was, with hindsight not a good move. I still have no idea at all why I did that.**

**Learning was not helped by the fact we were expected to master writing with the ghastly nib pens dipped in home made ink. History lessons were about learning the names and dates of irrelevant kings and queens. That was bad enough but on history exam I will never forget. I might have been nine. We were given a sheet of paper to write on. The paper was never top quality but the sheet I was given was unbelievable. It would have served its purpose better as blotting paper. All I can recall of that exam was the vile ink being absorbed by the paper and spreading out to make wonderful flowery patterns. I probably got none of answers right.**

**We all seemed to have permanently ink stained fingers, and yes, we used those china ink wells you dropped it the little holes in the wrought iron and wooden desks with lift up lid. I gather these are now popular curiosities picked up in auctions. Many will have the names of former occupants gouged into the wood and stained with ink. I am sure out there somewhere is one with the name W.Churchill engraved in the lid. It would be worth a fortune. Do I remember correctly that Winston was not an academic either?**

**My first brush with authority was over an altercation in one of these desks, I think in my first term. It was a double desk, semi-detached you could say. There was a bit of shoving and pushing going on but my shove was sufficient to propel my pal out of the desk and he ended up on the floor. (This was in a lesson of course!) I don't remember what the fuss was about or who started it, but I got the blame and was sent to the Headmaster, Mr. Mowll.**

**Terrified I retreated to the loos, and then went back to the class, having said that I had seen him. I was not street wise enough to realise the teacher would speak to the head later, which she of course did. This time the retribution was swift. The cane. I think it was six strokes. Was I emotionally damaged? I don't think so. Did it stop my mischievousness or make me into a 'goody goody'? No on both counts.**

**I was not the only creature to be on the receiving end of Mr. Mowll's wrath, but for the others it was more final. He waged war on his namesakes. Moles. If anyone saw an active mole heap, with the soil being pushed up to the surface, Mr. Mowll was to be told. He had two techniques to deal with these unfortunates. The first was to tiptoe up to the molehill and then blast into the top of it with his 12 bore shot gun at point blank range. The other was to used a croquet mallet, and rather like the way I split logs, whack it down onto the heap. Both techniques stunned the poor victim who was dug out and dealt with.**

**I was caned, slippered, plymsoled and on one occasion struck with a hairbrush by an enraged teacher, but never hit with a coquet mallet or shot. Be thankful for small mercies.**

**Before leaving Great Walstead I will tell you of some of the highlights in the school year.**

**On Shrove Tuesday we had pancake day. No races for us, this was a free for all, rugby scrum, in short a fight.**

**Initially it was class by class. The class would assemble in a tight pack behind Mr. Mowll, who with his back turned, lob a large pancake into the throng. We pounced on it and whoever after a couple of minutes pandemonium had the most was the winner. This was repeated class by class, but the climax involved the entire school. I cannot remember any rules or injuries.**

**Swimming. The swimming pool had been dug some years before I arrived. It was a no frills concrete lined hole in hole in the ground, but perfectly functional and I quickly learned to swim in my first term. One of the few accidents I remember was older, large boy coming a cropper on the spring board. The**

**details are vague but somehow he lost his footing and crashed down onto the edge of the pool. Ouch. It still makes me wince, but I don't think he broke any bones.**

**At end of the summer term we had the swimming sports. They ended when handfuls of coins were thrown into the pool for us to dive down to retrieve. When we returned to school after the summer holidays the pool was emptied and scrubbed out. There was no shortage of helpers because there were still some coins to find.**

**Fireworks on November the Fifth were the highlights of the winter term. A large fir tree would be felled in the woods, carried back to school by a gang of boys and set up as the centre pole around which the massive bonfire would be piled.**

**As with so many things Mr. Mowll had an imaginative way to do this. He had acquired one of those mobile fire fighting ladders, mounted on two vast wheels and counterpoised to keep it up. This was placed in position and with a group of boys sitting on the base, a line of boys up the ladder passed up branches to build the fire. Cunningly a tunnel was left at the bottom, so before the fire was lit on Bonfire Night ample flammable materials were inserted into the bowels of the heap to ensure a successful show. A cry went up when centre pole finally burned through and fell over.**

**Christmas was taken very seriously with the main school hall being decorated, a massive Christmas Tree, special meals and a carol service. It was an exciting and happy time.**

**Overall it was a very happy school and by a miracle I scraped though the Common Entrance exam so at 13 I went on to Monkton Combe School near Bath.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 8 part 6**

**Prep School Days and moving on.**

**I don't have an obsession with fire engines - honest, but after telling you how we constructed the mammoth bonfire for Fireworks night and mentioning the large wheeled ladder we used, I hunted the internet for a picture or two. I was astonished to learn these amazing devices had been made by the Merryweather company even before internal combustion engines. Have a look at the pictures. i have also added some fuzzy black and white pictures taken with my very first camera, of a Sports Day and the Swimming Pool.**

**So how did we get to and from Great Walstead? Haywards Heath is on the London to Brighton line, so the London based boys gathered on the platform at Victoria Station to board the train. I think the excitement of seeing your pals outweighed any separation anxiety and usually the journey was uneventful.**

**One January that was not the case. The weather was exceptionally cold and the train suddenly stopped. The points ahead were frozen. The train went back, presumably to find a way around them, but stopped again. By now the points behind us were also frozen. It was my brother who reminded me of this incident. We were on the train for several hours as it shuttled back and forth on a short length of track. During that time we ate every biscuit on the train but to occupy us we tried to think of as many words as we could ending with the letters -age.**

**Mr. Google tells me there are 441, that is not even counting the -idge ending words. Being little boys our vocabulary was pretty limited so along with the Ice age and the Stone age, we came up with the Cab age, Sew age and Spin age. I don't know if even the scientists had discovered the Bacteriaph age, and were were much to young to worry about the Remortg age and we knew nothing of Bond age. Nevertheless it was a good way to pass the time and would not be out of place today with families cooped up with children looking for imaginative things to do. Word games are a great way to explore the richness of our language.**

**Luggage, pun unintended, was sent ahead by train using a system we knew as P.L.A. Passenger Luggage in advance. David also reminded me that for a while Mr. Mowll rigged up a pulley system to hoist our full trunks to the top of the building, with a long rope attached to his car which he then drove**

**across the lawn. I don't remember this myself but it would have been typical of his ingenuity. Perhaps some things were just too hazardous even for him.**

**The deputy Head, who went on to be Head after I left GW in 1960 was Gordon Parke. He was a wonderful man. Considerate and wise. He and his wife lived in Walstead House, away from the rather forbidding main house. Senior boys spent their final year in smaller dormitories with the Parkes in Walstead House. The atmosphere was so much more homely and I remember this as a very happy time.**

**My school reports always had the word 'Excellent' in them. Unfortunately it was normally only once, and that was under the heading 'Health'. Academically my achievements were nothing to write home about. But I had learned a lot about Natural History by being having the freedom to explore the woods, the River Ouse, and farm. We all joined in picking the potatoes (using the school's fire buckets), and helped with the milking in the farm. Somewhere I have a picture of me riding cow. The skill was to get on when it was lying down, and then stay on as it stood up.**

**Sports day was taken very seriously by some. I was fit, but not exceptionally sporty or athletic. To be honest, competitiveness of any kind normally does very little to excite me. However, Mr. Mowll also recognised this, so on Sports day some of the races were certainly unconventional. The Fathers' race was one such "race". One year the challenge was to construct a wooden box from six pre-cut shapes using a hammer and nails. I don't think my dad and I won that one, but the next year we did, in style.**

**The Fathers' Race we won had an animal theme - of course! It was called 'Horse and Cart'. The son was the horse in front, blindfolded with large paper bag on his head and a piece of string, the reins, tied to each arm. The idea was for the father to use the reins to steer the son the 100 yards down the course.**

**Just as we were about to set off Dad whispered in my year "Just run as fast as you can!" I checked that I was pointing in the right direction and we just legged it. At the very finish I collided with a spectator but we won by a furlong. I think it was the only race we won. Our prize, I have just remembered was a small battery operated vacuum device for taking dust and hairs of your clothes.**

**So my days at Great Walstead ended. I just scraped through the Common Entrance Exam to get to Monkton Combe School near Bath, where I would once again be with my big brother David. Poor chap, he couldn't escape me for ever. It would be another year before the little grey cells were finally activated. That story is next.**

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**Have a good day everyone if you can. I know all too well the pain of losing your nearest and dearest, so my thoughts are with all of you who are worried about family members who are, for whatever reason, particularly vulnerable to the virus.**

**Hang on in there. The dawn will come.**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 9 Part 2**

**A life saving decision; recollections from Family Holidays.**

**I was blessed to have the most wonderful mother. I have said very little about her so far, but in due course I will tell you about her. Perhaps those of you who knew her might like to tell me of your memories of her which I will gladly weave into my story.**

**But this morning I will mention how she undoubtedly saved my life one day at Southwold, that very genteel resort on the Suffolk coast. (Until two minutes ago, when double checking it was in Suffolk and not Essex, I didn't know it was also on a River Blyth. Yesterday I needed to collect some textile to be sewn into long filter tubes to renew the sea water intake for the Great Yarmouth Sealife Centre, when I crossed our Northumbrian River Blyth. Just one of those curious little coincidences which seem to have peppered my life.)**

**So what happened in Southwold? I was about nine when we were together on the beach. Mother was on the shore and I was playing with a beach ball in the water. I had learned to swim the previous summer, and with the beach dropping quickly into deep water I was out of my depth.**

**The beach ball was only a few feet in front of me, but as I swam to get it she called to me very calmly, but with a serious tone in her voice "Let it go. We will get another one." Those eight words saved my life. I swam to the shore and when I turned round the beach ball was fifty yards off shore. My mother had seen how an off shore wind has whipped up and was taking the ball out to sea. I would have been determined to get the ball, and even if I had I would not have been able to swim with it. My mother had assessed the situation and her quick thinking saved me.**

**When Jamie and Zoe were growing up I would often say to them, 'there may be times when your immediate obedience might save your life. Please obey what we say, then you are welcome to ask us we told you to do it, and we will explain.'**

**It was that experience in Southwold which taught me that lesson.**

**Our Pembrokeshire holiday accommodation was far from salubrious. We had two caravans side by side on a farm near Whitesands Bay. A budget holiday without doubt, but one day I was in the smaller one when I heard squeaking from outside the back window. A family of weasels were playing around immediately below me. That was still the best view of weasels I have ever had.**

**We visited St. Davids, the tiny fishing village of Solva, but also took a boat out to the island of Skomer. Ten years later I spent a wonderful week on Skomer with friends from London University Natural History Society. On that occasion the boat's engine broke down on the longer return journey to Milford Haven but the captain was too proud to call out the lifeboat.**

**Eventually he started the engine, but by then we were thoroughly sea sick; but at least I am still here.**

**In 1955 I saw Scotland for the first time. The destination was the tiny village of Arnisdale, on Loch Hourne. I have just checked with AA Routes. The distance is 593 miles, and even with our modern motorways, expected to take 11 hours and 5 minutes. I just love the '5 minutes'. That August it took us 24 hours. Literally. The car was a Morris Isis estate car. We had had a Morris Oxford before that but, although it looked the same, this was the more powerful six cylinder version. Beds were made up in the back so over night David and I slept for much of the night.**

**What I have not mentioned was the storm. The weather was atrocious for most of the journey but as we neared our destination it improved and we had pretty good weather for the holiday, as I recall.**

**Although this was 65 years ago my memory tells me this was one of the best holidays we ever had. Where do I start? I saw Golden Eagles for the first time, circling over the hill behind us. (Beinn Sgritheall). Father approached the owners of the 'Big House' who gave him permission to fish for salmon on the short Arnisdale river. He did catch one on with a Devon Spinner, but I was beside him when a large salmon followed the lure right to the bank but didn't take it before father ran out of space and had to cast again.**

**Two miles up river are two small lochans. We took the rowing boat onto one of them and caught a lot of small trout. While on the water a small shower came over so for a few moment there was rain on one side of the wee lake, clear on the other and bright rainbow overhead. What small boy could fail to be impressed?**

**Despite the earlier storm, the north of Scotland had been dry for weeks and the rivers were low and very clear. As we stood on the road bridge over the river near Glenelg we could see a handful salmon below us facing upstream waiting for rain. I was the first to look over the other side of the bridge, where dozens and dozens of salmon were lying shoulder to shoulder. Another sight I have never forgotten.**

**Although we didn't go onto Skye we did take the steamer one glorious day. The gulls following the boat, bright white against the deep blue sky, and the best ice cream I had ever eaten were what I remember best**

**I don't know if father consulted the tide tables when booking these holidays. He may well have done because I remember beach combing at the extreme low spring tides. I'll tell you about that tomorrow.**

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I must stop now, and we've not even got to Chagford yet. I am sitting up in bed but my back is starting to ache which suggests I have written more than enough for you and for me for one session.

Today is Good Friday. It will be a strange Easter this year. 2020 the year of the pandemic which will perhaps go down in history like the Great Plague. Do you remember, (not personally but from the history books) how it ended? The Great Fire of London! There's a thought for you to ponder.

Keep safe and hope to see you on the other side.

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 10

Monkton Combe School. 1960 - 1965

Preamble.

Today is Easter Sunday which in the Christian calendar is the day which represents the triumph of Life over Death, a day to celebrate new life.

I am one of the "Baby Boom" generation. Wikipedia has some interesting words to say about us. I won't quote them now, but you can look them up if you wish. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Baby_boomers

Those of us born after the end of the Second World War didn't experience first hand the hardships and the loss of so many lives our parents did. We all know of the famous war stories such as 'The Dam Busters' and 'The Great Escape' which involved the daring exploits of young men we think of as heroes, but if we are really looking for inspiration from a group of people who endured sheer hell for years on end we should think of people like Anne Frank, the Jewish girl who with her family hid from the Germans in secret rooms behind bookshelves in occupied Holland from 1940 to 1944. I have never read her diary, but I now will. What we experience during the current lock down will not even come close to what they suffered.

May I wish you, your families and your friends a very Happy Easter. I wish you strength, courage, patience and love. Bless you all, most especially those of you in the front line, putting your lives at risk to save others. Most of all I wish you good health, mentally and physically.

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 10

Monkton Combe School. 1960 - 1965

So here we go, I have turned 13 and in September 1960 I boarded the train at Paddington Station to Bath Spa, where we were bussed to Monkton Combe.

David had already been there for a couple of years, so I had visited the school a number of times. It was four times larger than Great Walstead, and it was also set in lovely countryside, in a wooded valley, about four miles south of Bath. The river, or brook as it was called, was a great attraction for me, and now armed with rod and line, and a pair of old binoculars, I was able to explore, fish and birdwatch to my heart's content. These activities held much more attraction to me than the formal sporting activities so many of my fellow pupils seemed to be obsessed by. Rugby, or Rugger, Hockey, Cricket and Rowing were the main sports, with Tennis and the curious game of 'Fives' as minor sports.

The other organised activity was the CCF, the Combined Cadet Force. The majority were Army Cadets, but there was also a smaller, much coveted RAF section which had the ultimate prize of a flying scholarship if you were really lucky.

Then there were the clubs and societies representing a wide range of interest groups. In fact, Public Schools like this reflected the wider society as a whole. They were intended to prepare you for life, or as jokers often said, for life in either the Army or in Prison!

Authority was asserted not so much by the masters, (I don't think there were any female members of the teaching staff) but by the all powerful Prefects, or that's how they liked to think of themselves. The head of each of the five 'Houses', School, Eddystone, Farm and Grange, and lastly the newest 'House', Hill House of which I was a member, was a 'School Prefect'. Below them were the much feared 'Sub Prefects' some of whom wielded their power sadistically.

**Some of the school rules will sound so ridiculous and petty today that I will tell you about them. Third and fourth form pupils had to have their jackets buttoned up at all times. That's not all. You had to have TWO of the three buttons done. If you were caught with an open jacket, woe betide you. Fifth formers still had to have their jackets buttoned up, but need only have one button. But the sixth formers were free to show their elevated status by swanning around with their jackets unbuttoned. It still sounds quite bizarre.**

**The jacket was grey Harris Tweed, but in the Summer term you could wear a Navy Blue blazer. Now to reinforce status further, if you got into the top teams you were awarded your 'Colours' consisting of broad striped ties, or, in the case of the elite rowers, a cream blazer. The First VIII blazer was trimmed with a continuous navy blue ribbon, the Second VIII with alternating blue and silver squares on the ribbon.**

**The following incident occurred during dinner in the large communal dining hall. You have to picture 300 boys, seated nine per table. One boy would go to the serving hatch to collect the meal for the whole table. This evening the dish was ravioli in tomato sauce. A junior boy is balancing the full dish of ravioli on top of a wobbly pile of nine china plates. Head down and concentrating on not spilling anything he is making for his table.**

**Meanwhile, one of the prefects, resplendent in his newly awarded Second VIII cream blazer is strutting around more interested in being seen by all and sundry than on watching where he is going. The inevitable head on collision happens. I will leave the rest to your imagination.**

**Perhaps it was only a few of the Sub Prefects who were particularly nasty, but for me that was enough to steer me away from an aspirations in that direction. I decided very early on that I would mind my own business, not other people's. I would not openly rebel - that was sure to get you big trouble, but if I kept under the radar, I was sure I could follow my own interests without too much interference from the powers that be.**

**By and large this strategy proved to be very successful. I survived those five years. I made some lifetime friends and by and large I was happy and emerged unscathed at the other end. I (just) managed to get the 'A' Levels I needed to go to University. I hope I will not be labeled as 'a typical Public Schoolboy', I certainly don't feel like one.**

**In an earlier chapter I mentioned my house master, Mr. Baker whose catch phase was "You've got to learn to live together." As it happened he had had a challenging war time experience having been shot down over Germany. He spoke German so had managed to evade capture, but the story within the school was that for a number of years his nerves were still affected by what had happened. Like most of the masters, he was a genuinely kind and caring person, dedicated and professional.**

**The Photographs were taken in November 2019 when I took my granddaughter Maya out for the day. She lives in Bristol so we went to visit my old haunt, the Kennet and Avon Canal, (about a mile from Monkton Combe) on which I learned to ice skate in 1963.**

**The structure is the Dundas Aquaduct which carries the canal over the river Avon, and it was on the river Avon which the rowing took place.**

**Plenty more to come about life at Monkton.**

**HAPPY EASTER EVERYONE !**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 10 part 2**

**In today's narrative I will talk about a dramatic and, for some of my teachers, a very unexpected turnaround in my academic prospects at Monkton.**

**I think my experience may ring true with those written off as being 'thick' or perhaps in todays politically correct language, as 'low achievers'.**

**Monkton Combe School. The first 4 terms 1960/61**

**I mentioned earlier that upon leaving my Prep School in Sussex I just managed to scrape enough marks together in the Common Entrance Exam to be accepted by Monkton Combe School, near Bath in Somerset.**

**That is the truth and I can tell what happened. Approximately sixty boys arrived at MCS in September 1960. All but nine went into the Fourth Form, and would take their 'O' Level exams after two years. Nine, myself included, were unceremoniously dumped in the Third Form. We were expected to need an extra year to catch up. I accepted my place in the natural order or things and I believed I was 'thick'. At Prep School I had always been one from the bottom of the class. What was new?**

**At the end of that first term, six of the nine were moved up into the Fourth Form, and just three, myself included, stayed in the Third Form. In January '61 more boys arrived, and then a few more in the Summer term. Life in the Third Form wasn't too bad. I detested the Latin and French, but otherwise did enough to get along. I was not a rebel; just under the radar.**

**In September '61 we all moved into the Fourth Form, and during that term we started preparing for our 'O' Levels in earnest. These were the equivalent of the GCSEs of today. Our two Science subjects were Chemistry and Physics, both of which I found interesting. In Physics we disappeared into darkened rooms and played around with lenses, determining their focal lengths and creating wonderful spectrums of colour using chunky triangular glass prisms. It was great fun and the Physics Teacher's catch phrase, was "Units Laddie. What are they? Pink Elephants?" if you failed to write down the correct units, be they seconds or millimetres, with the numerical answer.**

**But in Chemistry there was this mysterious thing called VALENCY. Why was was the 2 in 'H2SO4' (Sulphuric Acid) or the 4 for that matter. Why was Hydrochloric Acid HCl and not H2Cl if water was H2O. It was all very very mysterious.**

**I don't know how it happened, but one day the scales simply fell from my eyes and I suddenly understood the concept of Valency. It became totally clear to me; almost easy. I don't think I had ever had an experience like this before. Perhaps I wasn't so thick after all.**

**The year group was split into sets, A, B and C. So it was perfectly possible for someone to be in A set for French, but in C set for Maths and the sciences. Guess where I was? Yes, C sets, right across the board.**

**Towards the end of that term we all set the same exam paper, but when the results were posted on the notice board, the chemistry staff had put all three sets' results on the same sheet of paper in three vertical columns. 'A' Set on the left, 'B' Set in the middle and 'C' Set on the right. I have used our noble Government's Coronavirus update's envelope to show you a very crude graphic of what that sheet looked like. (As you know I like re-cycling!)**

**I will explain. Our names were ranked in order, approximately level with the percentage achieved. As expected, the scatter of results was pretty well in line with expectations, with the 'A' set results at the top of the rankings, and the 'C' set at the bottom. But hold on, whose result is circled in orange? One of the 'C' Set results is right at the very top, level with the top marks of the brains in the 'A' Set. Yes, that was me! I think I had the third highest mark in the year.**

**The following term I was moved up into the 'A' Set for Chemistry and Physics. Other than French, which I fully expected to fail, I passed all my 'O' Levels. I then did my 'A's and passed all three, Biology, Chemistry and Physics, and got my place at Queen Elizabeth College in London University.**

**I am sure a lot of us will be able to relate to this story; if not for ourselves, for our children or grandchildren. Tell a child often enough they are 'thick', 'stupid' or 'naughty' and they will believe it. It becomes a self-fulfilling prophesy. Conversely, help them find their true potential, tell they CAN achieve whatever they hope, and there is every chance they will.**

**Tomorrow I will tell you about the winter of '63 and my sporting achievements, (or rather the lack of them), and badger watching, one of few opportunities to get out of bounds legitimately.**

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**Postscript. Yesterday the UK death toll for the Coronavirus topped 10,000 and is still rising alarmingly. Most people I speak to now know someone who has it, and many know, or know of, people who have died from it. We are in awful times, but we are also hearing of the wonderful selfless work of the NHS staff, of numerous acts of kindness and support for the isolated and the vulnerable. Let's hope as a society we will become more caring and considerate when we emerge from these dark days.**

**Keep safe. Keep strong. If you are feeling low phone a friend and see if you can cheer them up. That alone will cheer you up.**
**xxx**

**THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 10 part 3**

**The winter of 1963 was cold. How cold? This is from Wikipedia.**

**"The winter of 1962–63, known as the Big Freeze of 1963, was one of the coldest winters on record in the UK. Temperatures plummeted and lakes and rivers began to freeze over. In the temperature records extending back to 1659, only the winters of 1683/4 and 1739/40 were colder than 1962–63."**

**It was cold, in fact the third coldest winter in the last 360 years.**

**Although life was disrupted massively, education continued unaffected, unlike the sporting activities. 300 plus teenage boys need to let of steam, and since the normal winter games of either rowing or hockey the main alternatives were running, or a limited form of hockey played within the school quadrangle.**

**I never liked running for running's sake and runs were often given as punishments by sub-prefects for minor transgressions. This never bothered those who ran voluntarily. After they had fulfilled the required distance they mocked the punishment giver by saying they were going to do that run anyway. Not a good plan if the prefect had a good memory. Next time they might regret it.**

**So if you didn't like running and as a Rower, Quad Hockey was not an option, what else could you do to fulfil the obligatory requirement to take some physical exercise every day? By great good fortune, the father of one of my pals worked for Oxfam. They had just set up one of the first charity shops and he came back to school with a pair of ancient ice skates. The kind you strap onto the bottom of a heavy boot. My army boot, issued by the cadet force was ideal, so having roller-skated a lot at Great Walstead, I took to ice skating on the frozen Kennet and Avon Canal as a natural, and have enjoyed ice skating ever since.**

**The freeze continued for the entire term. On Wednesdays, we went out and about with the cadets, walking on the frozen snow over the tops of mature hedges. Every night we walked up the hill to our boarding house. In normal weather we walked up a local curiosity called a Drung. This was a footpath going directly up the hillside, between two stone walls. When we first arrived back at the beginning of term the Drung was packed with snow, so we walked up the field beside it, but as the snow between the walls compacted we were able to come back down the hill by sliding down a narrow Cresta Run type groove in the snow, one foot behind the other.**

**There were no serious accident caused by the freeze, but my classroom that year was in the old village school. Part of the old playground was a steeply sloping path up to the toilets. We had fun by pouring water onto the slope and sliding down the resulting ice sheet. That was dangerous enough for us who knew it, but one afternoon a senior boy who was coming to police, sorry 'supervise' our prep (homework) session, was caught unawares and had a nasty fall. He was not badly injured thankfully.**

**Not all of the senior boys fell into the mini-Hitler type of sub-prefect, full of their own self-importance and power mad. Most were very decent and caring. In my time in Hill House there were a few boys senior to me, all very clever and decent who went on to great things. Dearlove, became Sir Richard Dearlove, when he was head of MI5. Stilgoe, became Sir Richard Stilgoe, the impresario well known for his musical talents, first seen on Esther Ranzen's 'That's Life' programme, but the third was Bernard Wiggins. You might not know that name, but may well have read some of his books. He is now known as Bernard**

**Cornwell, best selling author of the Sharpe series of novels. For a while he was my 'Dorm Senior' and a good sport.**

**Monkton was good for me, and to me. Most of my friends would probably say the same. For me, it offered a lot of freedom, but for one of my best friends, Richard Cooper, whose family were farming in the Cotswolds, it was the opposite. He had a horse at home which he sorely missed and although he never rebelled, he was not particularly happy there. I last saw him in Australia shortly before he died, much too young.**

**The big freeze ended and the cricket and rugby pitches in the bottom of the valley flooded. Nothing unusual there. That is nature, they are flood plains, just don't build houses on them!**

**Running up the valley was a disused railway line, known a Clank. Shortly before the line was ripped up it was set for the 1953 comedy film The Titfield Thunderbolt, coincidentally just shown on BBC2 last week. The cricket pitch, known as 'Longmead' was in the scene when all the players rushed to see the train steaming by.**

**The following (summer) term we either played cricket, rowed and just a few played tennis. I rowed, and whilst not particularly good, I was reasonably competent. We learned the fundamentals in 'The Tank' a strange, recently completed contraption where the oarsmen sat on seats surrounded by the water. As you rowed, you stayed still, but the water went round and round. Quite ingenious in fact.**

**Most of the boats were 'fours' with four oarsmen and the 'cox', a small boy with a loud voice tucked into the stern steering the boat and shouting out the commands. The river Avon is too narrow for boats to race side by side, so a clever form of racing is adopted instead. All the boats are spaced out equally down the line of the river - pointing upstream. I forget the exact gap, but it is several boat lengths. Upon starting, the aim of the exercise is to catch the boat in front and touch their stern with your bow. At that point those two boats pull over to the side, so for the next race, normally the following day, the starting positions are reversed.**

**The oar hanging up in my hall at home was won by my father rowing for his Oxford College, St. Edmund Hall. (Teddy Hall) If you 'bumped' every day of race week, you were awarded your oar.**

**Regrettably my rowing career ended the following summer. I had realised that if I was to get my 'A' Level I was going to have to work very hard indeed. I was never a natural academic, and Rowing took up too much time. The teams went off for entire weekends to regattas scattered around the country, and whilst no doubt great fun, I had seen too many of the successful sporty types come a cropper with their exams so I decided to opt out and play tennis instead, just for fun and to get enough exercise. After all, you could play tennis with just one other person, and perhaps, just perhaps, that person might be wearing a skirt. 😉**

**I had made the decision to stop in principle, but the actual moment when I stopped was prompted by a silly petty decision by the senior boy coaching our crew on the day in question. The walk from the school to riverside boat house took about twenty minutes. We were meant to arrive five minutes before the official start time of the 'outing' to ensure there was no delay. On the day in question one or two of us arrived exactly on time, just as our boat was being disembarked by the earlier crew. The coach said "You should have been here five minutes ago. There's no outing today!" Strictly speaking he was within his rights to do that, but I suspected it was an excuse not to have to take us out that day. I also felt he could have punished the offenders in a number of other ways, but for me that was enough, and I told my tutor what had happened and how, for the sake of my 'A' Levels, I should give up rowing.**

**History proved that I made the right decision, but that day also coloured my attitude towards authority. I still think the spirit of the law is more important that the letter of the law - within reason! Respect everyone.**

Gun Games with the CCF.

I mentioned in passing earlier the CCF, the Combined Cadet Force. In many Public Schools there was, perhaps still is, a strong link with military. When I doing my PGCE, the grand sounding 'Post Graduate Certificate in Education', at Reading University, I did my teaching practice at Wellington College. The name alone suggests military connection, so even Monkton, set up to educate the sons of Christian Missionaries, had its CCF.

There is the expression, 'If you can't beat them, join them' so although theoretically one might have been able to opt out, in practice no one did. It was all rather gung ho. 'Jolly good fun chaps, this army lark!' Looking back it was frighteningly like the 'Oh Oh Oh What a Lovely War' attitude which prevailed at the outbreak of World War 1.

Training, on Wednesday afternoons, started with Square Bashing, or Drill. Itchy Battledress uniforms, spit and polish, literally, of the boot's toe caps, and being yelled at by the Sergeants, many of whom were the dreaded Sub-Prefects, but now with three stripes on their arms. It was amazing how soon we resembled a moderately competent fighting force. Drill required a degree of coordinating, and if you didn't have it already, you soon did if you didn't want to be given even more punishments.

I can still hear the words "STOP T L V RETURN" ringing in my ears. They are the commands for the About Turn on the march, with the T, L and the V representing the position of your feet. It was a brutal form of choreography, but nevertheless quite satisfying when you got it right.

Highlights of the CCF year were the Field Days on Salisbury Plain. We were issued with 'Blanks' and played "Gun Games' with great enthusiasm and lots of noise around the spookily deserted village of Imber. The village had been taken over years earlier for Army training, much to the fury of its inhabitants who had always hoped to get their homes back.

In the Summer holidays we were sent off to 'Camp' for two weeks, to one of the regular army training areas such as Lympstone in Devon, home of the Royal Marines. We engaged in exercises involving landing craft, assault courses and life in tents, which were inspected every morning for the precision with which your bed, pillow and kit was laid out. Generally good fun was had by all, unless you happened to be one of the nastier sergeants who, when making a real dog's dinner of an obstacle on the assault course was given a professional bollocking by a regular soldier, much to our satisfaction and amusement.

Back at school, trips to the rifle range near Box Hill were popular, perhaps more for the wall paper adorning the rangemaster's cabin than the prospects of becoming a Marksman. I was quite a good shot and remember with pride the day I was given my cloth Marksman's rifle which I sewed onto the sleeve of my battledress.

You will have picked up that I quite enjoyed the CCF. This was partly because during my second year, a more enlightened attitude prevailed, so instead of concentrating exclusively on Infantry training to the exclusion of everything else, new sections were started. The MT section, or Motor Transport, acquired and old car engine we stripped down and learned all the parts. By now, even I had been promoted so with my three Sergeant's stripes I was put in charge of the new Civil Defence section. This involved a journey into Bath where we learned to set up Field Kitchens with their Earth Ovens to feed the nation in the event of a Nuclear War.

One week we were shown a film which chillingly told us that we only had four minutes warning from the time the missiles were launched to the moment of impact. The next week, after the training we waited to board the army truck which would take us back to school. There was a problem with the garage door, but eventually, after SEVEN minutes, it was prised open. Not a good omen for our survival. It was very much along the lines of Dad's Army and a sense of humour helped get us through.

To put this period in context, there had been the First World War; we had been born just after the end of the Second World War, and with all of the nuclear proliferation, the Third World War just seemed to be a matter of when, not if. It was a scary time. We had the Cuban Missile Crisis, when the world held its breath, and we can remember exactly where we were when we heard that President Kennedy had been assassinated.

My early musical career was short lived. I couldn't master the Violin. I took one home to practice in holidays, but all I made was a vile din, so that went nowhere. I only briefly joined the choral society. The attraction of this society was an annual joint concert with the girls of Westonbirt school, but when the conductor waved his baton in a circular motion saying "There is someone singing out of tune around here" I knew I was in the centre of his circle, so I opted out of that too.

However, my musical career took an unexpected turn when a Military Band was set up to play at the CCF's annual inspection. The first instruments to appear were bugles. I was able to make a reasonably rendition of the Last Post, or Come to the Cookhouse Door, but then a number of side drums appeared. That was much more my cup of tea, so I learned to do a drum roll with the drum sticks.

When the band itself was formed there were plenty of volunteers from the competent musicians within the orchestra, but playing while marching was a challenge. The first afternoon we were told not to worry about keeping in step, just try to play while walking. Cacophony. Gradually things improved and by the end of the year the CCF staged a flood lit military tattoo, when the Band of the Black Watch accompanied us.

What I have not told you was the 'instrument' I ended up with. I played the cymbals! With great gusto and no complaints.

Next time I will explore the unexpected link between army training and natural history. The two photographs I posted today are relevant, and are there for you to think about before I explain tomorrow.

THIRD CAGE ON THE LEFT Page 10 part 5

The six S's and the motorbike.

Unlocking memories from the distant past.

One of the things I have found most enjoyable writing up my memories has been how by recollecting one particular event has reawakened the memory of another incident I had not thought about for more than half a century.

'Spit and Polish' was, and probably still is, quite literally how soldiers get an amazing mirror like finish on the toe caps of their boots. You get a cloth, add boot polish, then rubbing gently round and round for hours, adding spit from time to time. In time an incredible glass like surface starts to form.

In the weeks leading up to the CCF's annual inspection countless hours were spent (wasted?) on bringing our boots up to that standard. The problem was, just as you reached perfection it could all go disastrously wrong and the surface would disintegrate. This happened to one of my pals just before the big day. What to do? He took a gamble and painted the toe caps with gloss black paint. The inspecting VIP commended him on the high standard of his boots. Another candidate for SpecSavers?

Yesterday I posted two photographs of Roe bucks with my story and said I would explain their relevance today. I wonder if anyone has guessed the connection?

Let me explain. One of the topics covered in the army cadet training was Fieldcraft, and in particular how sentries or patrols can learn to hide from view using camouflage and concealment techniques.

A particular mnemonic was used to teach this - THE SIX S's.

Had I not looked it up, I would never have spelled mnemonic correctly. I would have started it with pneu....., but thanks to my friend Mr. Google, I can explain what a pneumonic, sorry, a mnemonic is.....

I. What is a Mnemonic?

A mnemonic, also known as a memory aid, is a tool that helps you remember an idea or phrase with a pattern of letters, numbers, or relatable associations. Mnemonic devices include special rhymes and poems, acronyms, images, songs, outlines, and other tools. Mnemonic (pronounced ni-mon-ik) is derived from the Greek phrase mimnēskesthai meaning to “remember.”

So now you know!

In teaching these concealment techniques 'The six S's' were Shape, Shadow, Shine, Silhouette, Surface and ....., well we used the word SHIFT for 'movement'.

I wondered if Google would reveal anything about this concept and to my surprise I unearthed a current Power Point presentation used to aid field craft training. The teaching technology has moved on, but the basic message is exactly the same, and it is the principles of concealment in nature which I love. That is why I posted the two deer pictures yesterday.

The younger buck, whose antlers are still covered in velvet, is standing right on the ridge, clearly silhouetted against the sky. The older buck is standing stock still in the shadow of a bush. (Can you see how his antlers have no velvet on them - he'll soon need to use them in earnest this year to fight off rivals who have their eyes on his ladies, so he has to have his antlers ready for action sooner than the young buck, whose antlers won't be needed for action for a year or two.)

The other side of the concealment techniques, are the observational skills you need to develop if you are going to spot creatures (or sentries) who are trying not to be seen.

One year a fox had her family in a den high up on the opposite side of the river but I could get a good view of it by climbing to the same level on our side of the river. The flat stump of a recently felled tree gave me a good seat, so armed with my binoculars, I took up a pad of paper to write letters while waiting for the action to start. On very still evening I was sure I had seen a movement below me. I then saw it again. When I checked it out I could see a deer's ear. It was attached to the deer, but that was all I could see of the animal, but flies were bothering it and the ear kept twitching.

The Monkton Combe valley below the school had an attractive stream, known as the Midford Brook. Although there were trout in the brook, I more often fished for Dace, small coarse fish which shoaled at one particular spot. One of the masters was a keen angler who took us to a nearby lake teeming with perch of which we caught plenty. This was a marked contrast with a funny incident on the canal. Richard Cooper (my friend was from the farm in Burford) and I were walking on the canal tow path when we saw a large perch lying still in the water. Just further up a couple were fishing, but they had had no luck, so we told them about the fish we had just seen. The chap pulled up the pathetic drowned worm, purporting to be the bait, and lowered it right in front of the perch's nose. Not only was the fish totally uninterested, it didn't even move away. Had I been that angler I think I would have given up.

I want to tell you about badger watching, bird watching and barbed wire, but I will finish today with a story of the motorbike.

My cousin Judith had joined the staff of Monkton Combe's junior school on Combe Down, just a couple of miles up the hill. Richard Cooper and I were having tea with her one Sunday afternoon when she told me about a motorbike one of the teachers had. It was a James Cadet, but the engine's big end, whatever that was, had broken and he wanted rid of the bike. I had been in the MT section of the CCF the year before so I was keen to take it apart to learn more about engines. To my surprise my House Master, Vic Baker allowed me to put the bike into his garage, so we pushed the bike down the hill and removed the engine which I hid under the desk in the study I shared with Richard Cooper.

We stripped the engine down, found the broken con rod, the bit which connects the piston to the cam shaft, and ordered a new one. When the replacement arrived we reassembled the engine and everything seemed to fit back into place. But would it work? To find out we needed petrol, so armed with a screw top jam jar we walked down to the garage on the Warminster road and were given enough petrol to test is. I think you could actually buy 2-stroke petrol from the garage, because that is what it needed.

That evening, during the 'Study Period' when we should have been doing our 'Prep' we got engine out from under the desk, poured some petrol into the fuel pipe, and with Richard putting all his weight on the bare engine block, I jumped on the kick start. To our horror, at the very first attempt the wretched engine burst into life. With no silencer the racket was dreadful so I immediately whipped off the spark plug and we stuffed the engine back under the desk.

As we did so, stomping up the corridor, a prefect was opening the other study doors. "What was that noise? What was that noise?" I don't think playing the innocent card and asking "What noise?" cut much ice, but luckily he was one of the decent Prefects and after explaining our project was with Mr. Baker's approval, we got away with it. Not all of the prefects were mean. Brother David was known to be very fair, and went on to have a distinguished career in the Police.

The engine and frame were reunited. We test ran the bike up and down the drive behind Hill House, and eventually the bike made its way to London. I even passed my driving test on it before getting a Honda 90 to commute from home to college.

Keep safe every one.